

Shadows of Titan

looked down, the five kilometres to the surface of Titan obscured by a thick layer of clouds. The airborne city was a work of wonder, one of Titan's crown jewels rivalling even Helion.

She turned suddenly, a high-pitched tearing sound screaming through the air. She looked to Taryn momentarily, but the sound wasn't coming from her. She squinted into the sky before seeing a massive, matte-black transport hurtling through the air so fast the front end was on fire. It crashed through the air-defence drones and into the plaza, the crystal floors shattering, sending civilians screaming and plummeting into the depths of the building. The coffin-shaped transport groaned, the end tearing open as a massive, multi-jointed steel claw ripped through the metal.

An alarm blared overhead, the plaza's speakers immediately issuing warnings:

**THREAT LEVEL QUASAR: ALL CIVILIANS EVACUATE! HOSTILE
UNREGISTERED BIOMECHANICALS DETECTED! CITY-WIDE CIVILIAN
EVACUATION PROTOCOL INITIATED!**

Nyx's heart raced as her shaky hands fumbled with her comtech, trying to establish an emergency pathway to Darius, but it was still restricted. She whirled around, trying to put together her thoughts. She needed to get the civilians out, but the only way was to warp them. She had never warped this many people without touching them, and the nearest safe platform was a little more than a hundred metres away.

She gritted her teeth and started anyway, the energy ebbing out of her body with each group. She didn't focus on the monster; she hoped Synn and Taryn could at least delay it while she pushed harder. There were hundreds of people in the chaos around her, the civilians' screams blurring away as they found themselves shooting through space and time to safety.

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She heard a screech behind her that sounded like Taryn, and she pushed herself harder, faster. Her eyes were clouding slightly from the blood leaking from her tear ducts, and she felt the cold grip of panic set in. She couldn't save all the survivors and have enough energy left over to fight whatever had just fallen from the sky. But she didn't have a choice.

As she found the last civilian she could see alive and warped them to safety, she felt a small prick of relief as she opened her comtech. It was an incoming call from Commander Voxx.

"I'm en route," his voice crackled through the speaker. She spun to yell to Taryn and Synn, but another monster was already there. She gasped, *there were two of them*.

Twenty-five feet of hulking metal and seething with anger, the monster's fist caught her chin sharply. She rocketed into the air, barely leaving time to create a barrier before she received another blow. Its strikes came hard and fast, not giving her an opening to defend herself as her body crashed through an emergency drone. She used the temporary cover to get her bearings and fire a shot of re-forged metal at the monster. It deflected off, not even leaving a scratch as she came crashing back to the Spire's destroyed upper floor. She pulled herself up to see Synn unconscious, a bloody mess in Taryn's lap. Blood was dripping from Taryn's mouth from using her Sonic Rend too many times, but her mouth still hung open slightly as she tried to force sound out. Nyx pushed with power, creating a small rift in time, slowing the monster and using her other hand to warp both of them away to the other survivors.

She felt a staggering blow to her back, almost making her black out. She tried to dissolve it, tear its energy from it, but the acid-ridden metal didn't budge. She felt the burn of the acid flood through her system, and she flinched back. She felt the monster pull back, and she tried to run. She saw it pull back to pull out a massive cannon. She could feel the energy dampening coming from it and dodged the first shot just in time. The shot exploded behind her, causing the

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spire to shake as the crystal broke, sending them plummeting to the floor below in a shower of crystal and twisted metal. The other monster rose from the floor and pulled a massive sword from its chest, flaring to life in a fizz of energy and acid.

Before she could breathe, they were on her again and she shot a powerful beam of pure energy at the monster, blasting through its arm. It earned her a direct punch to the gut, sending her flying into the open air, blood flooding her mouth and spewing into the atmosphere. The monster leapt after her without hesitation, its arm springing back into place to prepare for the next shot. Rocket-type fissures in their backs propelled them through the air towards her and she felt the world go hazy as she tried to dodge, zig-zagging her way through the frigid sky. The monster with the cannon fired again, the nullifying shot grazing her, draining her power. She stuttered in the air before falling like a stone.

The second monster was on her in an instant, its sword oozing acid as it raised it for a killing blow.

She was going to die here.

With a scream, she created a disc of solid space, kicking off it and sending herself shuttling sideways, smashing into the crystal ceiling of the adjacent spire. She felt spiderwebs of pain crack up her legs as she landed hard, skidding across a polished obsidian floor and crashing into the glittering art installations. The two monsters landed seconds later, their immense weight cracking the spire's floor.

“Kill. The. Strongest,” the monster in front of her grated, dragging its acid-sword behind it, the acid eating through the obsidian in sickening rivets.

The other monster was already charging the cannon, and she was in a point-blank killing shot. Nyx tried to raise a shield, but her powers were still sputtering.

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She was going to die here.

The thought screamed through her skull as she tried to warp away, blood pouring from her mouth in the effort. She looked down to see her leg almost completely shattered, and her ribcage sitting unnaturally. She didn't feel any pain, but her body refused to heal, refused to move.

She bowed her head as a sonic boom shattered through the air. A blur of silver light slammed into the monsters, the force driving the monsters through the wall and back into the air. Voxx knelt beside her, his command suit almost immediately soaked in her blood. "You are a mess, little mouse," he hissed, his voice thrumming with anger. He turned and rocketed through the new hole, his wings flaring to form a defensive shield, engaging the monster with the massive sword in a brutal clash for dominance. His wings acted as shields and blades as he slashed through the monster's claws, causing it to spew acid in the air. It hit a high-speed transit line, the civilian carriage plummeting into the clouds, dropping down to Titan below.

Nyx pushed herself up, pulling matter from everything around them, the building shaking as she dropped obsidian spikes hard at the monster, sending the cannon flying. The monster converged on her, landing a sickening blow to her jaw. Her head snapped back and she tried again to absorb the energy and turn it into dust, the metal groaning around its frame. It spewed acid at her in a shower and she tried to cover herself with a shield, the acid burning her skin. She screamed, the pain shocking her body, and her energy fluctuating wildly.

"Get back!" Voxx screamed from above her, his voice amplified by his power. She tried to scramble out of the way as his six wings melted together in a cascade of light, reforming into a singular pair of colossal wings.

The Dreg chasing her looked up, shrieking at him defiantly.

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“Annihilation: Collapse Sequence!” His voice radiated coolly as he unleashed a devastating rain of solar projectiles. Thousands of them poured from his wings and slammed into the crystal roof and engulfed both the monsters. They screamed in pain as the energy superheated their metal armour, finally melting through their impenetrable exterior.

She saw her chance and focused what was left of her energy on the monsters, hurling a spear of energy through them in a vicious implosion of dark energy. The monsters staggered, one’s limbs locking in place completely, its body sagging under the melting metal.

Voxx ignited his wings in a burst of celestial light and heat, his body radiant from the energy. “Holy Divine Treasure of Pride: **Ego!**” His voice sliced through the chaos, golden sigils bursting into existence in the air around them. Voxx dove forward, his energy magnifying through the sigils, turning the world white.

Nyx hit the floor hard from the shockwave, the top of the spire bursting open and shattering into the atmosphere. Heat washed over her, and she heard the monsters screech in pain as they were vapourised.

The building tilted precariously, crashing into the Helix Spire next to it, hurling Nyx's body through the glass and out the broken walls.

“**Myth!**” Voxx screamed as he dove for her, his wings flickering violently, the right one hanging on by a thread.

She felt her eyes fog over as they plummeted into the cloud layer, the world around becoming a swirling, disorienting mess of white and red. The freezing air whipped past her and the lack of oxygen numbed her senses. Her world darkened, and she hoped that Voxx could catch her before she fell to Titan’s surface below.

Chapter 32

The air around him was freezing and the wind screamed past in a deafening roar. Voxx could see Myth's limp and bloody body disappear into the cloud layer. He knew the mechanical mess that sprawled below the glittering clouds would tear her apart.

I can't lose her.

His wings were still fused together, refusing to re-form, tearing him apart as the bone cracked and his flesh burned from the flood of energy.

He burst through the cloud cover to see Myth bounce off a high-speed rail tube like a rag doll, spinning wildly in the air from the impact. He tucked his wings tight and dove harder, the

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wind cutting his face like a knife, his eyes screaming from the pressure. He caught her just beneath the last grav-ring, his arms and head tucking around her, his wings pulling tight, cocooning them in. He poured his Solar energy into a hard shell around them as he felt the first impact. A thermal conduit sliced his left side open, blood spraying through his wings. He felt a support beam shatter through his right wing in a scream of metal and exploding ice. He pushed his head down harder as they hit the guts of the structural spine. He was thrown temporarily sideways as he bounced off a fire-suppression pipe, the pressurised burst freezing against his back. He gritted his teeth as they slammed into the ground layer of Aetherion, the maintenance tunnel exploding upward in a shockwave as his legs crashed into the ground.

Everything went white with pain, his leg snapping sideways abruptly before everything blinked black.

He surged back to consciousness with a ragged gasp, his lungs searing with each breath as he tasted the foul, metallic air. His eyes blurred over, almost blacking out from the suffocating pain. His head drummed agonisingly and he felt the cold crushing through his bones. He struggled to push himself onto his elbows, trying to separate his body from the freezing ground. His wings were gone, just ruined sinew hanging from his back like dead roots. All six were completely torn from their sockets, his nerves twitching, sending shockwaves of pain thrumming through his back. His left leg was shattered in three places and a shard of steel had impaled him through the right shoulder. He was pinned to a twisted pipe, the icy-cold metal burning his flesh. He tried to look around, but his right eye was completely swollen shut, a pulsating mass of bruised flesh. His mind whirled dizzily; Myth wasn't making a sound and he couldn't see her. A jolt of terror cut through the fog of pain and snapped him into action.

GET UP!

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His mind screamed at him, a desperate plea to his battered body. He pressed his hand to the gushing wound on his shoulder, focusing his energy. Slowly, searing heat erupted under his palm. A scream tore from his throat as the energy cauterised the flesh. He snapped his teeth shut, the white-hot agony and smell of burning flesh threatening to consume him. But it worked, and the bleeding slowed to a crawl from the exit wound, the blood congealing in the cold.

He looked down, his voice a hoarse whisper. "Sorry." He pressed both his hands to her shattered leg, the raw Solar energy lancing out of his fingers. With her leg severed, the wound sealed off immediately, burning the skin shut in a crude patch. The smell of burnt flesh rushed through the air and Myth cried faintly, passing in and out of consciousness.

His body spasmed from the effort; blood gushed from his nose and he almost blacked out again. He collapsed forward over her, his hand shaking violently. He rolled her onto his back, the sinew and fried energy veins scorching in pain as he forced his energy inward, raising his body temperature and creating a small dome of protective heat around them. It scorched through his system, his body shaking violently from the exertion, his eye blurring over. He briefly tapped his arm, confirming his comtech was dead, and gritted his teeth. He had to think. They had to get out before they froze to death.

He began to drag them mindlessly, feeling his blood freeze behind him. His energy began to crack over his skin, the Solar flares erupting in bursts as his control started to fail. His body convulsed on the frozen ground, Myth almost sliding away as he grabbed at her, his vision flickering from the pain, his shoulder and back screaming for relief.

A sterile room, a glint of a needle.

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He forced his body up again, biting down on his tongue and forcing Myth onto his back.

“She won’t feel a thing.”

He snarled, spitting blood from his mouth and dragging himself forward. He followed his nose, trying to find a scent, or a wisp of warmer air in the dark. His head was ringing constantly and his balance kept slipping sideways, the dark suffocating him. The air was thick with rust and dust, wires hanging like webbing, slowing his progress. He felt a warm wisp of air to his left and he immediately slung his body towards it. It felt like a maintenance corridor, barely big enough for him, let alone Myth.

He fought his rising panic and gingerly slid her down to his crushed legs, the pain ripping another scream from his throat. His eyes darkened and his energy flickered violently. He dropped his shoulder and dragged his body through, her limp body precariously balanced on his broken leg.

It was a desperate crawl in the dark, the temperature slowly rising, spurring him on. He finally reached the hatch at the end, but it didn’t budge. His fingers clawed at the rusted edges, the ice cutting into his fingers.

He took a deep breath, trying to steady his breathing, a cold thread of dread setting in. He slammed his shoulder against the hatch. It shuddered, cracking open, a sweet scent wafting out. He threw his whole weight against the opening, his energy surging in desperation. It gave way with a metallic screech and the warm air hit him like a dream. Bioluminescent moss lit the grove in shades of blue and green, and a soft breeze wafted through the leaves overhead. The sun was setting, casting everything in an eerie orange glow, bright in his eyes after being in complete

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darkness. As he dragged himself out of the maintenance pipe onto the soft forest floor, he barely caught Myth's dead weight, his arms screaming in pain.

He blinked hard, trying to focus, his world spinning in a dizzying arc of pain and exhaustion. It seemed what had made the clearing was a monstrous-sized sequoia, its trunk hollowed out by time and lined with thick moss.

The air hit his lungs, sweet and strong. Sunlight. She was laughing ahead of him, her bare feet quick against the soft grass. Her dark hair a tangled mess of braids and wildflowers, flowing behind her.

He squeezed his eyes shut, trying to block out the memories, throwing his body forward, dragging them to the tree. His mind was swirling painfully as he tried to think of a plan if something was nested inside. As he approached the entrance, a flock of Crested Phasurs took to the sky, their massive wings brushing against his body in a rush of colour and sound. They were bright, crystal-like creatures, their plumage shimmering in the fading light, their eyes wide with fear as they fled the intrusion.

He dragged Myth behind him into the hollow, her body like a broken doll in his arms. He pushed farther in, briefly checking the interior before laying her gently in the feather-lined nest.

Her condition was terrible; he brushed her matted hair from her face, and she stirred just enough to let him know she was still alive. His mind warbled, darkness threatening to set in.

He dragged himself forward, the icy ground scraping against his broken leg.

It was pouring rain; they were soaked. She was laughing against his chest. "Put those wings away and enjoy the rain, Thal!"

Smiling at her, he bent down and kissed her gently, her lips sweet and warm.

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Pain shot through his body, sending him rushing back to the present. With shaking hands, he gathered nearby rocks and sticks. His fingers were cut and bleeding, making every touch excruciating. Soon a small fire crackled to life, the last spark of his energy setting it ablaze. A glow danced along the wooden walls, the heat immediately filling up the cosy space. He sank against the wall, his body savouring the warmth, his eyes blurring over.

His eyes slipped shut.

She was screaming his name. He was thrashing against enforcers, trying to break free. Her eyes were wide and wild. "Please don't let them take me!" she cried.

"I promise I'll come get you!" he screamed, his voice cracking as her small frame was dragged from the room.

"Such emotional children," a chilling voice said behind him.

He jerked, his grip on consciousness slipping; he turned to look at the nest. Her breathing had steadied out, but her body was a disjointed mangle, her right leg's stump muddy and covered in burnt blood.

His head drooped heavily, the firelight dancing and twisting around him, his eyes slipping closed. He felt his body surrender to exhaustion, his last thoughts a swirl of worry and pain.

Chapter 33

Darius stood rigid as the medical aide finished up next to him. “All clear,” the young man chirped cheerfully, tapping the datapad with clinical precision. He didn’t respond. Signing his release silently, he quickly grabbed his gear.

He wasn’t a prisoner, not officially, but he felt like he was in a cage. As the terminal door hissed open, he strode out into the entryway; the silence was deafening. The white lobby wall-display was on a silent loop. The Helix Spire was partially destroyed, and the Tertiary Spire gone entirely.

His blood ran cold as Myth’s battered image flickered across the screen in a glitchy loop. She was screaming, hurling a beam of energy at the monsters that was terrifying. In the next clip, she was falling through the sky like a ragdoll, her body limp and bleeding heavily.

He moved without thinking, running to his transport and pulling his comtech up. Dozens of missed calls, all blocked by a channel restriction:

CHANNEL RESTRICTED BY HIGH CHANCELLOR'S DIRECT AUTHORITY

Energy screamed through his body, replaced by a roaring inferno of rage and guilt. He would worry about Mereen later; he clenched his jaw until he felt pain in his molars. He engaged his transport's emergency override, the ship launching into the upper stratosphere. He noted the hundreds, if not thousands, of brightly coloured transports blurring past him. All medical units, T.E.B., and military shuttles. His eyes quickly locked onto the chaos below. The damage done to both spires was devastating, the debris shredding the civilian districts below.

He checked his comtech again, but still nothing from Myth.

He didn't wait for his transport to find an empty dock and leapt down, his boots ringing like a boom against the crystal. The air in Aetherion was thick, his nose filling with a sour blend of smoke, blood, and burnt ozone. Emergency drones hummed overhead and med-techs swarmed the hundreds of triaged civilians.

He found King and Solaris with the T.E.B., both badly battered. King's uniform was scorched black, and Eira had a wound running from her collar to her ribs that was being patched by a medic. They both started when they saw him.

"Where were you?" King rasped, his voice raw.

"The High Chancellor," he snapped, looking through the busy crowd. He finally spotted who he was looking for and weaved through the makeshift med-beds until he came upon Synn. The young man's body was almost fully covered in compression gel, bandages, and splints. He gave a weak salute when he saw Darius. Taryn sat nearby, her dirty hands shaking violently. Her throat was wrapped in medical gauze, her lips split and crusted with dried blood.

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“Captain.” Synn struggled as Darius knelt between them.

“Lie down. Talk,” Darius murmured.

“A transport. Funeral-class fell from upper orbit. There wasn’t a warning or a flight path...” His voice broke. “There were two monsters inside and they tore through on impact.”

Darius clenched his jaw but waited, letting him catch his breath.

“There were civilians everywhere and Nyx started warping them out, but there were hundreds. Taryn and I tried to hold the monsters back, but...”

Taryn made a raspy sound, blood gurgling from the corner of her mouth. She quickly wiped it away, her eyes full of tears.

“She screamed herself mute,” Synn said. “Her Sonic Rend... she wrecked her throat, but it bought Nyx some time.”

Darius nodded slowly, his pulse thudding in his ears.

“Commander Voxx was able to get here in time to help take them out, but the fight collapsed most of the upper Helix Spire and the top sections of the Tertiary Spire. The debris fallout is immense; a lot of civilians are dead. Nyx was unresponsive in the fall and Commander Voxx went after her. They haven’t come back.” Synn’s voice broke.

Darius stood slowly, trying to control his emotions. “You two are relieved from duty on full medical leave until further notice. You performed outstandingly today.”

Taryn nodded, tears streaking down her bruised face, and Synn looked like he might faint from exhaustion. He laid a gentle hand on Synn's shoulder before turning, his comtech already open. He quickly scanned through the trajectory data and structural overlays as he walked back toward the rescue hub. The crystal corridor groaned under the makeshift metal scaffolding. It

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was still lined with evacuees wrapped in silver thermal cloaks, waiting to be transported out. Eira and King stood where he had left them; King's face was etched with a rare hint of exhaustion.

"So what happened?" he asked, his voice low.

"**Fane.**" Eira almost spat the name. "I think it was a test," she continued, her voice clipped. "Fane's real monsters aren't like the ones we took down in the Catalyst Wells. These are armoured, fast, resistant to direct energy attacks. Even ice slows them down by only a fraction."

King turned, his arms crossed over his damaged chestplate. "He withdrew. Probably a data-gathering run, testing his monsters against our best."

The weight of his words hung heavy in the air, a grim acknowledgement of their vulnerability.

"So he won," Darius said flatly, his pulse spiking so fast it made his ears ring. His mind screamed with questions: *How many more of these monsters did Fane have? What was he going to do next?*

"We need to be stronger," the General said. "We didn't even stand a chance today."

"And we need to find Voxx and Myth, if she's not already dead," Eira said, her expression a mix of anger and determination.

"We **cannot** let it leak that they are gone," King bit out. "If Fane attacks again while we are missing some of our best assets..."

"I'll find them." Darius nodded once before turning away. He grabbed a full med-pack and stormed back to his transport.

He raced through the debris field, descending lower and lower into icy Aetherion depths. The damage was sprawling and severe. He marked the worst-hit areas, where he saw civilians trapped under the latticework or signal fires had already been set. His comms crackled to life. "I

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need a T.E.B. unit for these coordinates,” he barked. “Medical and cryo-evac teams needed on standby.”

“Copy that. Units en route,” a voice immediately crackled back.

He took manual control of the transport, the understructure of Aetherion, a frozen labyrinth of shattered metal and sheared-off crystal support beams. He reached the ground level of solid ice and metal, and exited his transport into the sub-zero terrain. It was deathly quiet, his boots mute against the howl of the wind as he crunched over the frozen ground.

He moved lower, following the trail to the entry point, the snow and ice battering his face. They had broken clean through the platform, the entry going through several of the sector’s deepest layers. There were dozens of craters where metal had almost punctured through.

As he lowered himself into the frozen underground maze, he saw sprays of blood across the walls and ice-covered floor. The smell hit him next. An overwhelming scent of burnt flesh hung in the air. The acrid smell caused his nose to sting as he saw chunks of Voxx’s armour lying scattered amidst bits of wing membrane.

The energy from his body flared instinctively, trying to push back the suffocating icy air, illuminating the narrow passageway as he gently hit the floor. What he saw made his heart stop.

Myth’s leg and boot lay twisted and crushed, a jagged end where her body should be. Blood sprayed across the adjacent wall in a radial splatter, frozen mid-burst.

What was left of Voxx’s wings was spread around the ground, looking like they had exploded on impact. His silvery blood mixed with Myth’s in a macabre, frozen display.

Bile rose hard in his throat, sour on his tongue and threatening to choke him. He forced himself to move forward, following the thin, frozen trail. Voxx had managed to drag her, and the lack of footprints showed that neither had been walking. The trail didn’t go very far; the lack of

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blood and frozen temperature probably slowed their blood loss. His energy battled with the black frost, but he could feel the cold numbing beneath his armour. The passageway was straight, but there were hundreds of side-corridors. Substation maintenance hatches, disused geothermal conduits, frozen bio-storage lanes. All in an endless maze of metal and ice.

His breathing was ragged now, the ice catching in his throat and lungs the quicker he moved. The main tunnel didn't curve, but felt like it continued on in the dark for ages, doubt clawing at his mind if they even made it this far.

He was about to turn back when the floor gave way to nothingness. He flared his energy just in time, catching himself on the edge, his heart hammering. He pulled himself up, his fingers freezing as he made contact with the cold metal. The opening stretched into a vertical chasm of pure black. A dead end with a geothermal shaft, probably kilometres deep at best.

Had they come this way? No one would survive a fall like that, regardless of their condition. Did they veer off into a side-tunnel? And if so, which one?

Darius clenched his fist, fighting the rising panic in his chest. The T.E.B. and medics were already spread thin, and a full search team would take hours. And if Myth and Voxx were dead, the news would spread like wildfire.

He turned back down the passageway, activating an emergency beacon on his comtech. Pinging for any comtechs or SOS signals, he started running. Somewhere in this maze, Myth was badly hurt and running out of time.

Chapter 34

She woke up with a start, a jolt of pain snapping through her, dragging her awake. Her body was stiff; every nerve felt like it was on fire and her mind was sluggish. She heard a crunch and she blinked hard, trying to make out the shapes in the dark. Feathers, shimmering in hues of red and blue... was she in a nest? A brightly coloured bird was pecking at a shape slumped near some dying coals. Voxx's massive frame was curled awkwardly at the entrance, his body a mass of black, silver, and flesh.

She tried to move and her world instantly went dark, a sharp, piercing ring slicing through her ears as her body screamed in protest. Her face was radiating with pain, her jaw hanging loose, her bottom teeth missing entirely. She tried to scream, but could only force out a gurgled gasp.

The birds startled, fluttering towards her curiously, their wings beating the air against her face before their bodies disintegrated in mid-air. Her body tried desperately to pull what little energy it could out of the birds, her energy relentlessly looking for any energy source. She felt tears stream down her face as she peered at Voxx in the darkness. He looked dead, save for a small quiver of his chest. If she stayed near him now, she would drain him, her body screaming uncontrollably for any type of energy. Her arms wouldn't cooperate and she tried to drag herself

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out of the tree, the nest disintegrating under her body. She tried to move and the world tunnelled again, white pain flashing through her, leaving her disoriented. She looked down at her body, her vision swimming with tears and pain.

Her legs were gone. One was completely pulverised, a tangled, twisted mess of flesh and bone. The other was entirely gone; only a cauterised stump remained of her right leg. Every breath felt like she was suffocating, the smoky and musky interior closing in around her as she felt horror flood through her veins. The pain was relentless, radiating down her shoulders and back. She threw her body desperately forward, her shoulder slamming back into its socket with a sickening pop. Pain exploded down her spine and her jaw split further, a fresh wave of agony making her vomit. She choked back the bile and blood threatening to drown her.

Voxx stirred, his body twitching, his eyes flying open. They were bloodshot and confused, his body slightly uncurling. “Myth...”

His voice cut through her like a knife, alarm bells screaming through her mind. She tried to mumble a reply, but her jaw flapped uselessly.

“Thal... Thallion,” she rasped, holding her jaw in her good hand. “Move... get... help.”

He shifted, his legs thumping to the side before he collapsed fully, the movement taking what energy was left out of him.

She dragged herself forward slowly, her body screaming in pain. Each movement was a blunt shock of pain, her nerves screaming, her arms trembling violently. She dragged herself inch by inch, her elbow burning and bleeding under the coals as she dragged her body through the ashes.

When she finally pulled herself out of the tree, she tried to survey her surroundings, but all she could see was dark. There was a faint blood trail leading to a dark, frozen mouth. The

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closer she got, the more frigid the air became, frost coating the softer grass beneath her. Her body sagged against the threshold; her mind screamed to stay awake, but she could feel the darkness clouding her brain. A silvery feather, jagged and soaked in silver blood, twinkled at her ahead, ripped off by the base of a maintenance hatch.

She leaned her body heavily against the metal opening, and was met with a responding shriek of metal. The sound was high and sharp, splitting the silence like a blade. If someone was looking for them, surely they would hear that sound? Her body ached in a kaleidoscope of pain with every movement as she fought the encroaching hopelessness. She moved the icy hatch back and forth; her muscles began to spasm and the screeching got weaker, her arm finally giving out. She rolled onto her back gasping for air, trying to find Voxx's form in the darkness behind her. Using her hips, she struggled back to Voxx, agony gripping her like a vice. He had to wake up. If he had his comtech or anything that would make a noise or a signal, she needed it. She didn't want to die. Not here.

Tears streamed down her face as she felt another wave of pain rip through her body. The moss and grass beneath her fingertips became dry and brittle, her body trying to draw from anything and everything to keep her alive. Her throat gurgled, a fresh rush of blood pouring out.

"Voxx!" she gasped, her voice mumbled. She cried harder, desperation seeping through her senses. "Com..." She needed him to wake up and try his comtech. She needed him to wake up.

A scream of frustration tore from her throat as she gave her body another push over the cold, wet moss, barely clearing her head from the puddle of vomit and blood under her.

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“Myth...” She heard Voxx’s voice above her, his voice faint and distant. “I’m coming. No matter how many times they make me forget you... I’ll always come back.”

Pain lanced through her mind, confused, jilted memories flooding through her brain. She couldn’t think, she couldn’t process, and she felt her head drop further down. She tried to scream, call his name, scream for help, to ignore the pain crashing through her body.

Her thoughts were becoming more jumbled, her mind slowing down, her adrenaline wearing off when she felt a rumble through the soft clearing. The maintenance hatch vibrated slightly, a distant voice distorted by the metal echoing faintly. She tried desperately to scream again, pushing past the pain of her shattered jaw, letting out a strangled wail. Her vision swam, the cold world spinning as a wave of pain wracked through her. Her blood felt ice-cold in her veins, a numbing feeling beginning to seep into every fibre of her being.

She heard the hatch scream open, metal bending and tearing as a flood of fire and light burst into the clearing. She squinted in the sudden light to see Darius’s body entirely engulfed in orange and blue flames. He had torn through the maintenance hatch, already speaking into his comtech in a sharp voice.

His eyes widened and he turned to run to her but stopped, frozen mid-motion, his body tense. Her energy was already pulling at him, his energy flaring in a protective barrier around him. She tried to form a coherent thought, but her mind finally gave out, his face a bittersweet image to carry her into fitful dreams.

Chapter 35

She woke to a blinding white light bearing agonisingly down on her. Her body was shaking with hunger and cold, her energy lashing out wildly. She was completely naked in a sterile metal room, strapped spread-eagled to a massive steel X-frame. Her hands were completely encased in metal gloves with heavy energy-suppression needles digging into her wrists. Her shoulders and hips ached where her body hung lopsided, her missing leg causing her to sag unnaturally.

She tried to fight the rising tide of panic, but her body shook so violently she thought she would faint again. Her hair was crusted and matted, hanging over her face in a tangled mess, obscuring her vision. Her jaw still hung slack, her mouth a mass of shattered teeth and bleeding gums. Her tongue was hanging and swollen, choking her cries.

A speaker crackled overhead, the jarring noise making her flinch, her body desperately trying to get away from the cold frame.

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“Now, now. None of that, Nyx. My name is Dr. Ekros,” a cheery voice echoed through the room in a sickeningly sweet tone. “I am attended by the esteemed High Chancellor Mereen and your very own Captain Valkyrie.”

Her head snapped up, her vision flashing white in pain. She strained to see through the tangled mess in front of her. She could just make out a window in the wall, massive and thick with reinforced glass. Behind the glass, she could see the bright teal gloves of Dr. Ekros, the dark outline of a woman, and the unmistakable fiery presence of Darius.

She fought wildly against her restraints, a desperate attempt to break free.

“What did I tell you about that, Nyx?” Dr. Ekros’s voice echoed through the room, sharp and commanding.

A powerful shock jolted through her body. Brutal, searing pain that made her scream in agony. Her body contorted and jerked, her eyesight blinking in and out in disorienting flashes. The frame shocked her for what felt like an eternity, finally shutting off, letting her body hang slack against her restraints.

“We have run a very detailed analysis of your mutation energy, Nyx,” the High Chancellor’s cool, detached voice came over the speaker. “In this state, you are just much too dangerous, hence the restraints. We do not have a permanent, efficient containment option for you. That leaves only one clear solution: to terminate you.”

Nyx’s mind swam, a sense of terrible familiarity crawling at the edges of her memory. The silence was deafening.

“But... perhaps... if you can stabilise yourself... we can come to a different solution,” Dr. Ekros’s oily voice echoed into the silence.

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A wall panel slid open with a seeping hiss and three gurneys rolled in, each bearing a terrified, naked Dreg strapped prone to the gurney with shackles. Only one prisoner was sullen, his eyes defiant with silent fury. The other two begged and sobbed uncontrollably, their voices a desperate plea for mercy.

“Don’t fret, Nyx! These are criminals!” The doctor’s cheery voice rang out. “One is even a serial murderer. You’ll be cleaning up the AAN prisons! Doing the world a favour really!”

Nyx’s body shook violently, her mind recoiling in a mix of horror and revulsion, the reality of her situation slamming into her with brutal force. She felt the relentless, gnawing agony ripping at the very fibre of her being, begging her to give in as her mind swam.

“I hate to rush you, Nyx. But you must make a decision. Now,” the High Chancellor’s voice rang out.

The prisoners’ screams filled the room in a cacophony of terror that echoed through her mind. Her body convulsed in pain, desperately trying to reach towards the Dregs, their energy flaring in response to their panic. It was them or her. Her resolve crumbled, her energy surging out, twisted and dark, disintegrating everything in its path. The first Dreg disintegrated in a blink, leaving nothing but a whiff of dust behind. The other two went berserk, trying to use their energy to protect themselves, causing her energy to swell, ravenous and unquenchable.

Her body began to itch and swell, an uncomfortable sensation drenching her skin. Her jaw slowly tightened, the broken, jagged edges of her teeth closing around her tongue.

“More! We need **more!**” Dr. Ekros called out, his voice strangely bright.

Her eyes glazed over, her mind foggy as she did it again. And again.

And again.

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Each Dreg that was brought in clawed and screamed, the terror on their faces a knife to her heart. *Monster*. They all screamed as her body slowly rebuilt from their very essence. Her teeth slowly regrew, gnashing as her jaw healed. Her leg visibly started to heal, the burnt stump elongating and reshaping, leaving her skin slick and raw.

“It seems the lower-tier mutations do very little for you,” Dr. Ekros called out, finally halting the parade of prisoners. “We will begin the synergy trials.”

Nyx felt her blood run cold, bile rising in her mouth, her face flushed with humiliation.

“Now, Captain Valkyrie. You will synergise to finalise the healing. We must observe the energy exchange post-feeding,” the doctor's voice rang out, sharp and high in her ears.

Darius walked in slowly, his face tight and stressed. He had a haunted look in his eyes, his jaw set tight.

“Please, Darius, no,” she whispered, her voice a broken rasp. She could feel the High Chancellor and the doctor watching, their eyes like cold knives against her skin.

Darius brushed her hair from her eyes, his voice a low, urgent whisper. “If I don’t, someone else will. Or they will kill you.”

She felt her tears spring up anew, a fresh wave of panic threatening to consume her. She nodded once, trying to steel her resolve against the onslaught of emotions that threatened to consume her.

“Monitored synergy is more common than not. I’ll be careful,” he said, moving behind her, his voice ringing quietly in her ears.

“Let’s get this on with,” the Chancellor's voice rang out, impatient and sharp.

She felt his warm hand on her shoulder before she felt the searing inferno of his body. She cried out, her back arching from the pain as her body was flooded with his energy as he

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entered her. The overwhelming force left her gasping and trembling, her body surging with a reluctant, unwanted pleasure.

The energy feedback was immediate, his body burning brightly with the sheer intensity of his power. It scorched through her mind, an all-consuming force that left her breathless and dizzy as he moved steadily against her, his arms lifting her slightly, easing her joints. The pain instantly subsided from her shoulders and she felt her body finally healing fully. But there was a tinge of something foreign to his fiery energy, an unsettling sensation that pinched at her mind, her thoughts becoming a tangled mess.

“Enough.” The Chancellor's voice cut through the haze sharply.

“Yes. Captain, you may take her, but the tracker shall remain active at all times,” Ekros said with a disappointed tinge.

The restraints opened with a hiss and Darius caught her quickly, covering her body with his uniform jacket. Her eyes slid closed immediately against the white light, her body going limp in his arms, her mind fuzzy and blank as he moved without a word.

She woke as he walked through his room and straight to the bathroom. His touch was gentle and careful as he helped her shower, her hair a matted mess of blood and viscera. She still struggled to form a solid thought, her mind a twisted and chaotic haze of thoughts and energies.

She didn't say anything until they were tucked into his bed, his warm body pressed tightly to hers, his arm tight around her.

“Darius,” she whispered. He jolted slightly, turning to look down at her.

“Your energy... when we... Are you okay?” she finished in a whisper, her face burning.

He didn't answer, just pulled her head to his lips, kissing her gently on the forehead. She wanted to push the subject, to demand to know where he was, what had happened with the

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Chancellor. But exhaustion won out and she fell into a restless sleep. In her dream she was calling desperately for Darius, the feelings of despair and hopelessness playing twisted games in her mind.

Chapter 36

Voxx surged awake, his eyes flying open in a disorienting burst of white light. His head swam as he tried to move his body. It felt like an insurmountable pressure was pinning him down, and the disorienting reality of what had happened made his stomach churn. There was a painful void where his wings used to be, his back a mess of fused nerves and torn tissue. His legs and shoulder throbbed relentlessly, the thick IV line in his arm combatting the waves of pain.

He looked around slowly, his body braced and suspended between anti-grav fluid and a sol-gel solution. He was in his AAN recovery room, a familiar place of healing and torment. Echoes of the past flitted around him, brutal and unforgiving reminders of the battles he had fought.

The drugs tugged at him, muddling his thoughts, his reality fraying painfully at the edges. He blinked hard, his eyes straining to focus. The far corner of the room was awash in golden

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light, covering Myth in a soft glow. She sat cross-legged in an overstuffed ball chair, sketching absent-mindedly on a pink pad of paper. Her silver eyes were alight, her dark curls bouncing as she hummed something under her breath, a familiar tune buried so deep not even a memory purge could scrub it from his soul.

He couldn't breathe, and he felt his lungs constricting excruciatingly, his heart pounding in his chest like a trapped animal. She glanced up upon hearing the monitors spike, her face breaking into a bright smile.

"Thallion!" she squealed quietly. "You're awake!" She stood in a fluid motion, ecstatically approaching the edge of the bed. She was a fuzzy haze, not limping or bleeding, her face unmarred.

"You really got wrecked up this time, Thal." Her voice was like a melody, twirling in the fogs of his mind. "Let me guess, Ekie let one of his tests get out of hand?"

He couldn't respond, his throat closing around the overwhelming feelings threatening to bubble to the surface. His fingers twitched against the bed frame in a futile attempt to reach out, his muscles spasming painfully. He faintly heard alerts beeping wildly as the room shifted violently, dissolving into a kaleidoscope of memories and illusions.

They were beneath a canopy of silver trees and her hand was cupped around a glowing Cryoglass Lily. She looked at it in awe, a soft smile on her face. "You know they only bloom once in their life," she whispered. He looked down; her face was bleeding, streaked with ash and blood. He felt the ground give way around him, his body hurling through concrete, sending a phantom shockwave through his body. She was bending over him in a haze of smoke and fire. "Run," she whispered before turning, her body glowing. "I said **RUN!**" she screamed. She was missing an arm, her face battered and fearful. As he numbly turned to run, his entire world was

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engulfed in searing white; he barely felt his body leave the ground before he was rocketed into space, the force from her energy finally detonating. His ears rang painfully and he turned to reach out to her. Bits of her body were blown far, broken and curled around the rubble, the entire sector a wasteland from the blast. He gritted his teeth, knowing it was futile to go back, to pick up her pieces. He took off into the dark night, the frigid air icing the tears on his face. Faster and harder he pushed, his eyes blacking out and blood pouring from his mouth.

He abruptly found himself standing still, the small pagoda-style patio around him. It was a spring cycle, and soft cherry-blossom petals drifted through the air, tickling his nose with their sweet scent. She was there again, laughing and dancing, twirling barefoot on pink musical tiles as they played a haunting melody. “Dance with me, you coward!” she teased, her hair flowing around her in waves. “Or are you scared?” Her laugh rippled through the air, a twisted symphony against his soul. He walked slowly to her, gently taking her lithe body into his arms. Her hand held his cheek, soft and warm, and he couldn’t help but lean into her touch. His heart ached as he looked into her bright eyes. “I failed you,” he finally croaked, the floodgates breaking free. He felt his heart slow down to a crawl, his mind aching for peace.

“I’m here now,” she whispered soothingly, pulling his head down to her shoulder.

There was a rushing in his ears as he surrendered, savouring the feeling of the weight dropping from his shoulders. He felt hot tears pour down his face, his eyes finally darkening over, his world slowly fading. “I’m so sorry, Myth. I am so sorry.” A painful shock jolted his body like fire, followed by a brutal echo of voices calling out above him. Shrill alarms were sounding somewhere above him, and he clung to Myth, desperate to stay. His body jolted again, the shocks ripping him away in a rush of white and agonising pain.

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He blinked hard, feeling small, warm hands on his chest as energy poured into him. His body twitched and contorted violently as the hallucination was fully ripped from his grasp.

“I thought you were dead,” a soft voice breathed with a sigh of relief.

He felt his body violently knit back together and he bit back a groan of pain. His eyesight finally focused and he saw Nyx bending over him, breathing hard and sweat beading on her upper lip. A lance of pain shot through his head. Nyx, not Myth. Nyx was who she was now, someone who didn’t remember him, didn’t remember anything. She was surrounded by med-techs, and one was holding defibrillator paddles. He shuddered as he took a deep breath, a flood of sterile air and cold washing through him. His nerves calmed and his mind cleared, the drugs clearing out of his system as she healed him.

“I’m going to come back before the morning,” she said, her face pale and her hands finally cooling. “I promise.”

He nodded. “Thank you.” His feelings twisted as she turned and walked out. He noted her body was slightly battered, her normal black and purple replaced by beige hospital colours. There was a large collar around her neck and his stomach churned with what that meant.

The door opened as soon as it closed behind her; High Chancellor Mereen came sweeping in, her energy slicing through the room. Her white face was drawn into a tight pinch, and she was flanked by Lynx Kairen, his face a mask of relief and worry.

“Commander,” Mereen said, standing stiffly at his side. “We thought we lost you there for a moment.”

He nodded, but waited for her to continue.

“Dryst’s escalation has drastically changed the parameters under which we need to operate, as I am sure you know. His biomechanical anomalies are not only Quasar-level threats,

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but they are coordinated. Even though the majority of the Helix Spire stands, the damage they did was truly catastrophic. Not just to Aetherion, but to our image.”

She lifted a sleek datapad from her side, shoving the glowing page under his nose. A new directive, crimson-stamped with the full Council’s seals: **TITAN’S HERO ACT**.

“Though the damage in Aetherion is contained, somewhat, the Verge convoy was lost. The T.E.B. is overstretched and Dregs everywhere are getting criminally restless. We are being forced into this war with Fane, and we are wildly unprepared.” Mereen flipped the pad back around, turning to pace slowly.

“We have let sentimentality and tradition weaken us. Raw power is not sufficient anymore. And as the AAN evolves, so must you evolve!” she proclaimed, her voice ringing with confidence. “Once Nyx returns and finishes healing your wings, you will be outfitted with Dominion Aileron Augmentations. They will not only maintain your wings' structural integrity, but also supply eighty-nine percent more energy on their own. You will also be fitted with a Core Resonance Modulator, to not only stabilise your energy, but amplify it. The AAN has unanimously decided that the age of flesh and bone is over. And you will be the first, and then the rest will be similarly outfitted.”

Voxx’s mind spun, everything in his body wanting to refuse, cycles and cycles of training and injuries screaming in his mind.

“Recovery is anticipated to be hours. Upon success, you will make a public appearance. People are scared; they need hope. And you will give them that hope. We will not lose to chaos, to fear, or to Dryst.” She turned in a flurry of white. Techs started to flood the room, prepping it for surgery. Lynx, who had been standing stoic and still near the door, gave both Mereen and Voxx a crisp salute before swiftly departing. Mereen turned to follow him, stopping one last

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time. “I’ll prep your speech. Nyx will be in while you are in surgery to finish your recovery.”

And then she was gone.

He let his head fall back against the gel, feeling the prick of needles in his arms. He would be stronger, and he would kill Fane once and for all.

Voxx stood in front of the mirror, his gaze scrutinising. His posture was rigid, the weight of his uniform across his shoulders feeling like a second skin; the familiar armour that had been seamlessly reforged radiated brightly with his energy. The AAN had updated his uniform from silver and white to silver and black, every edge shimmering with the newest reactive technology.

The operation was a complete success, as was Nyx’s healing. The augmentations allowed his wings to be massive, almost dwarfing his body even folded behind his back, the resonance modulator seamlessly integrated with his energy, allowing for massive energy storage. He would need it if he was going to wield any resonance weapons.

He turned from the mirror and approached the charge pad with measured steps. Two weapons rested in their frames: The Judicator. A massive, double-edged sword that flowed with arcs of energy, softly pulsing as waves flowed from its white-gold blade. The second was the Scythe of Ego. It had a ten-foot arc of pure niobium, the haft and blade moulded with the AAN crest, illuminated white from within by the immense amount of Solar energy it stored.

He sheathed The Judicator carefully as the door behind him slid open, revealing Lynx waiting with his T.E.B. badge lit.

“How do you feel?” Lynx asked in a low voice.

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Voxx looked down at his hands, flexing them, feeling the warm new strength coursing through his veins. “Exceptional. Are you ready?”

Lynx nodded and they walked together in silence, the soft hum of hundreds of reporters coming from the entry rotunda. As he stepped through the doors into the early morning light, their voices clamoured into a deafening roar. The flash of cameras bathed him in white light as he walked forward. Valkyrie, King, and Solaris were already at the press podium, speaking calmly into the cameras for their prospective houses.

As he stepped into place, silence settled immediately, and expectant eyes all turned toward him. He wasted no time and launched into his speech, his voice strong and stable:

“Good people of Titan. I am here today with a heavy but hopeful heart. Aetherion did not fall. But it was, brutally, attacked by **monsters**.” His voice echoed with authority, the rotunda so still you could hear a pin drop. “These are Fane Dryst’s monsters, and in his war on us, he also wages a war against Titan herself. His aim? Planet-wide extinction.”

The room shifted suddenly, murmurs breaking out among the press.

“So, the Aegis Ascension Nexus calls forth a new initiative,” he boomed with a flourish. “The Titan Hero Guard. Any Echelon, Luminal, or Apex who wants to defend this world may undergo the Hero Trials. Unlike the Apex Trials, these trials are non-lethal. They will be open to engineers, first responders, and non-energy residents. Upon completion, the AAN will immediately begin issuing Hero Guard Licenses. Once licensing is acquired, you are sanctioned to join a Hero Agency or even start your own. So if you wish to protect your home, your sector, your people, I encourage you: Register. We will stand together, as one. As Titan.”

Chapter 37

Myth sat stiffly on the couch in Darius's room, the mix of fresh air and perfume adding to her restlessness. She was alone, and fragments of the night sliced through her mind wildly. The events of the day before felt like a lifetime ago. So much had happened. They had woken her and Darius at oh-four-hundred hours and oh-six-hundred hours to heal Voxx. It had taken a lot out of her, but she had lied to Darius and said she was fine. She turned to the screen that was playing the early morning press conference on a loop.

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Voxx stood tall, bigger and more terrifying than ever, the press adoring every word he said. He was flanked by Darius, Eira Solaris, Seren Kaelth, General King, and Lynx Kairen. It was like everyone was there... except her.

Her feelings roiled unsteadily as something cold and sharp coiled in her gut. She moved, dragging her heavy limbs from the low couch and heading towards the shower. The heated floor soothed her feet, and the scalding water was a welcome distraction from her thoughts. She tried to push the Dregs' faces out of her mind as she scrubbed her skin raw, her nails scratching her skin, leaving thin red-silver trails of blood. The tile beneath her blurred and her eyes stung as she choked back a sob, her throat contracting painfully.

She heard her comtech chime and she quickly exited the shower, patting her face furiously with a towel. It was a message from Darius, and she knew what it was going to say before she even read it:

**I am running point for the Forgedeep Hero Guard. Sector-to-sector oversight.
Won't be back until late. Stay in the suite.**

She stood frozen for a moment, her body panicking even though she couldn't place exactly why. With shaking fingers, she tapped into Vexal's secure line. Her mind struggled to formulate a message, but she finally wrote:

I need to debrief.

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She quickly dressed, trying to ignore the silence as she donned a simple black outfit, the energy inside her scratching painfully in her veins. She jumped when she heard the single ping, almost tripping over her trousers as she reached for her comtech.

Big O. In one hour.

An hour? She felt the familiar swell of panic in her throat, and she bit down on her cheek until she tasted iron. The morning had already felt like an eternity. Her hands trembled violently. She couldn't stay here; she would at least get out for a walk.

She reached for energy, focusing her warp, when she felt a stab of agony detonate through her spine. Her body was thrown across the room into the far wall, her muscles seizing, pain causing her to see flecks of white and red. An alarm screamed from her neck:

QUASAR-LEVEL ENERGY DISCHARGE DETECTED. BIOLOCK INITIATED.

She struggled to breathe, her jaw locked tight and her heart screaming in her chest. Her mind swirled in a hazy mass of thoughts, the pain making it impossible to think. A faint shadow stopped in front of her, Dr. Ekros's face coming into view as he stooped down. He wore a faint smile, a look of clear amusement on his face.

"Oh, dear," he murmured coldly, tilting his head. "Going somewhere? These dampeners do have quite a bite to them, but they're there to curb any disobedience. I am sure you understand."

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His face distorted in front of her as the energy crackled through her body one final time before subsiding. She felt his clammy hand against her shoulder, the moistness seeping through to her twitching skin.

“All that excess energy, my child. You are going to flashcrack if you don’t get that fixed.”

His face was sickeningly smug. “The dampener will not like that, not one little bit.”

She rose slowly, her muscles screaming, trying to catch her breath. Ekros watched her, making a show of brushing an invisible speck from his sleeve.

“This will shock me every time I use my energy?” Her voice was dry.

“Indeed,” he replied gleefully.

“Get this out of me!” she screeched.

He looked up at her with a dismissive puff of air escaping his nose. “No. I can’t. The most I can do is spoof it for maybe an hour.”

Her hope curdled.

“But I know a man. He can reprogram it, then extract it. Maybe track whatever your last vitals were and complete your location tracks as scheduled... possibly.”

Her mind whirled, alarms dancing across every nerve. “Why? Why help me?”

“Do you want to be like an Ash-Crawler or not?” The look he gave her was unimpressed.

She shook her head, but remained silent, not trusting herself to speak.

“One hour,” he reiterated, his fingers dancing over his datapad. A green light pinged on her comtech, with a set of coordinates popping up. “Then the leash snaps back.”

She didn’t thank him, just nodded. She didn’t trust him, but she didn’t have any other choice. She pulled her energy tentatively, relief flooding through her body as she warped quietly away, the world dissolving away from her body.

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She stumbled on impact, her boot almost giving way under her. The floor was slick with acid runoff, and the corroded steel floor had jagged holes peppered throughout. The air was a furnace of toxic steam and smoke as she tried to make out where she was, her pulse screaming in her ears. Maybe she had warped to the wrong place. She turned uncertainly, barely making out that she was in a repurposed reactor core.

“Myth.”

The sound of her name hit almost like a physical blow, and she whirled around to see Fane Dryst.

“No,” she breathed, denial rushing through her body, panic crashing in.

A ghost of a smile touched his lips, but he made no move forward. She wanted to warp away, but to where? She couldn’t go back to the suite again, she couldn’t see Vexal with a tracker in her neck, and time was ticking. Fane was watching her intently, his face unreadable before he walked slowly to the far chamber wall, motioning for her to follow. She followed him hesitantly through the heavy metal doorway, the space beyond surprising her. It was a spacious but cluttered workshop; tools and disassembled tech lay scattered across rusted tables and cabinets in functional chaos. The lights were yellowing with age, and the whole shop was bathed in an almost cosy glow.

Fane dropped into a heavy chair and gestured to a stool in front of him. “So,” he said, his tone disarmingly casual. “You want that leash out?”

She nodded, her mind still reeling.

“Sit.”

She walked over slowly, lowering herself onto the stool. He gently turned her by the shoulder until her back was to him and pushed a grimy standing mirror toward her with his foot.

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“Take your shirt off.”

She stiffened.

“The tracker is subdermally implanted in your spine,” he explained.

She nodded once before taking her blouse off, the warm air of the reactor rushing over her body. She manoeuvred the mirror until the reflection showed the bruised skin between her shoulder blades. She could see a long incision that had a faint green glow peeking through the stitches.

“No anaesthetic,” he warned, picking up a scalpel. “This will probably hurt.”

She bit her lip and gave a nod, watching as the first cut left a burning, clean line, the white stitches giving way cleanly.

“Ekros sent you,” Fane mused, his eyes so black his pupils were invisible in the dim light. She watched his deft hands work, the pain quickly subsiding as her body relaxed.

“He and I,” he continued, “have an understanding. And a shared *disappointment* in the AAN.”

“You made those things...” was the only thing she could think, her voice holding a ring of accusation to it.

“I did. Were you impressed?” He seemed not to notice.

“They are monsters!” Her voice rushed out finally.

“They are tools,” he corrected, his tone easy. “Obedient, single-minded, and effective. You’ve been a tool too, it seems. So, what’s the functional difference?”

“They killed people!”

“And? It seems like you are getting quite the body-count as well.”

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His response hit her almost like a physical blow; memories flooded through her mind, causing her body to shiver slightly.

She was silent for a long moment. “Why?” she finally whispered.

His hands never stilled, working with an assuredness that shocked her. “Because the Aegis Ascension Nexus is the biggest lie ever created. They preach evolution and pure bloodlines while engineering every single person in a lab. The Apex. A *product* line. Helion Prime has an entire Biogene lab the size of a district. Incubating the next, the best, and the brightest. The rich get custom upgrades and the poor hope for the promise of more. The whole system is upheld by the blind loyalty of the natural-born. I will destroy it all. And from the ashes, I will build the New Titan.”

She fought the feeling of dread washing over her, his words ringing in her ears. He spoke with no malice, but matter-of-factly. Her mind whirled with thoughts and questions, finally swirling around the most haunting one.

He shifted behind her. “The dampener is now broadcasting a loop following the standard expected schedule. Indefinitely. Now for the extraction.”

She braced against the front of the chair, pain lancing across her back as he began to dig.

“So how does that make Apexes not human?” she gritted out.

“I am saying that humanity is a spectrum. The first Apexes were just mutated survivors of the Catalyst surges. Dregs. Their DNA was scrambled by Titan’s radiation and the foreign energy of technology they didn’t understand. The AAN harvested anyone they deemed unworthy, slowly mutating themselves into a patchwork of stolen parts.”

The knot in her stomach tightened. “So what does that make me?”

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He was quiet for a long time, his face drawn as he chose his next words. “You wouldn’t believe me if I told you,” he said finally. “Go to the Helios Vault if you think you are ready to know. See it for yourself.”

She wanted to ask more, but he was finished, already standing as he applied a sealant and a bandage. He handed her the implant, its many wires squirming wetly across her hand. She quickly dressed, thinking carefully before warping the device into her boot in Darius’s room. The last place anyone would look. She stood uncertainly for a moment, watching as Fane carefully washed his hands.

“What do I owe you?” she said, her panic setting back in. She should have asked him before; if he asked for something terrible, she would—

“Nothing,” he said, walking back to his worktable.

She stared at him, her head spinning in confusion. “You and Ekros... just helping me out of the goodness of your hearts?”

“It seemed like you could use a win. And your freedom is a strategic asset,” he said, already engrossing himself in a mass of wires and circuit boards.

“Thank you?” she said, the words almost catching in her throat, her mind racing.

“You’re welcome, Myth,” he said without looking up.

She waited a beat before focusing her energy, warping away in a haze of confusing feelings and jumbled thoughts.

Chapter 38

She landed in the Big O hard, her hip slamming against a smooth desk in the main entryway. The impact rattled her bones, but she barely noticed. There was the hum of the generator beneath her feet, the floor warm and steady. The lights were low, and her breath caught slightly in her throat when she saw him.

He stood in front of a wall console, muscular arms crossed, his posture easy. He was watching her quietly, his left eye gleaming faintly with calibration lines. She had tried her best to heal him the last time she'd seen him, but he looked even better now. She couldn't explain why.

She moved forward rapidly, the words tumbling from her lips before she could stop them. "Dr. Ekros put a tracker in me. When I tried to warp it... I asked him to take it out and he said he couldn't, but he knew someone who could. He sent me... He sent me to Fane."

Vexal's eyes sharpened as he straightened. "Fane? And he let you go?"

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She nodded. “And took the tracker out.”

He didn’t question her further. Instead, he motioned her towards him, a scanner coming to life in his hand as he guided her to sit. The pressure of his gloved hand on her shoulder was comforting, his face calm as he swiped through his interface. A few long seconds passed before he stepped back, putting away the scanner and crossing his arms over his chest. “You’re clean, and the AAN isn’t raining down on us, so... you’re good to go.”

Myth closed her eyes briefly, relief washing over her. Vexal stepped back to the console, his gaze locked onto her. “So he helped you,” his voice came low. “Fane. Why? What did he get out of it?”

“He didn’t want anything. He talked a bit about the AAN...” She let her voice drift off.

“And?” he asked patiently.

“He told me things about the Apexes. About the system. Where I can go to find out more about me,” she breathed.

Vexal was silent for a long moment. “He always tells the truth when it will hurt the most. Come on. We’ve moved locations.”

“Because of Fane?” Her question hung in the air a beat.

He nodded and turned, jerking his chin for her to follow him. She padded quietly after him, her boots echoing faintly against the cool metal hallways as they entered the auxiliary hangar. His transport was a dull, deep grey, matte-plated and heavily modified. The inside cabin hummed softly; the encrypted nav-system was noticeably lacking an autopilot. He sat in the pilot's seat, his arms flexing as the door sealed behind her and they lifted off. She leaned into her seat as he banked hard and dove into the under-channels.

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She watched as the lower sector of Titan's highways buzzed around her. She had never seen such large industrial carriers and water carriers, their purple maintenance lights dancing against the myriad of transports ducking around them. She watched Vexal, fascinated as he manoeuvred them skilfully through the traffic, his body relaxed against the seat as if it took minimal effort.

"You were hurt in Aetherion." His voice was quiet, cutting through her thoughts like a knife. The silence was thick around them, the engine noise a soft lull in her ears. "What happened?"

Her fingers clenched around her knees, her mouth dry as the memories came flooding back. She gave him a brief overview of Fane's monsters, the fight, and what happened with Voxx after. She felt a few stray tears sneak out as she told him about the forced feeding, even Darius. She fought the worry threatening to consume her as she realised the implications of Commander Voxx actually knowing who she was. She left nothing out, and when she was done, she let out a shuddering laugh. "I didn't realise infiltration would be this hard," she said weakly.

"Do you want to come home?" Vexal's voice was calm, but his jaw flexed visibly.

They flew in silence for a long moment, her thoughts whirling through her head at lightning speed.

"I don't want to make you feel like you have to do this. You wanted to get close to King to get answers. Even if it's not through King, you have them now," he said.

"You wouldn't be angry?" she asked hesitantly. "What about the rebellion?"

"Of course not," he said, giving her a look of mild surprise. "Our war isn't like Fane's. Not with monsters or chaos. We are waging a war against the infrastructure itself."

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He leaned back again in his seat, his silver eyes fixed on the under-channel ahead. She finally noticed his hair was braided back instead of the loose waves he always had. His coat was a heavy black leather, the length down to his large, steel-toed boots. He was clean and pressed, the normal soot that tinged his face gone.

“My loyalists are already registering to create their own Hero Agencies. They will not only get AAN funding, but they will hire Dregs as well as Echelons and Luminals. Anyone willing to protect their sector, regardless of their energy index. As more Dregs and loyalists infiltrate the system, the quicker it will fall.”

She didn't respond right away, his voice like a balm across her nerves. He banked the transport out of traffic gracefully and into the graffiti-scrawled walls of the maintenance tunnels. She watched as the kaleidoscope of colour and droids sprawled across the pipes and conduits. He increased their speed until she only saw a blur of bright blues, yellows, and pinks flitting past her window. They exited in a burst of light, a massive reactor dome abruptly in front of them. Dozens of terminals pulsed with activity, and modified transports docked and exited through a refitted hangar bay. The air thrummed with life as he brought them to a gentle stop, docking the transport with ease. The bay was swarming with Luminal engineers and Dregs, working side by side. She even caught sight of a few Echelons moving crates, their lower-energy powers flitting through the air brightly.

As they passed the final checkpoint through a reinforced entryway, she followed him into a makeshift war room. Weapons schematics lined the walls, and tech relays hummed, with massive maps of Titan's underground network sprawled across the central table. The chamber itself was circular, embedded deep into the shielded core. Screens flickered with live feeds of all the sectors, tracking the movement of allies, sympathisers, and enemies.

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Lyra stood at the central table, her purple hair longer than when Myth last saw her. Her fingers danced across a kinetic map, her expression pinched with concentration as violet energy pulsed faintly at her fingertips. Beside her Korric loomed, his massive dark hands tapping carefully through a weapons manifest.

She bit back a choke of surprise as the Ash King AI's voice drifted through the room, his humanoid body coming into view with Bryn Alaric. It seemed as if they materialised together out of the shadows, deeply engrossed in conversation.

As soon as he looked up, Bryn's expression froze, and for a split second he paused before he gave her a small nod, going back to his conversation, leaving Myth confused and slightly unsettled.

"Good," Vexal said, stepping forward. "You are all here." He turned to her briefly. "Myth, I'm assuming you know Bryn Alaric? The High Chancellor tried to install him as a mole. Once he learned who we truly were, he became a loyalist too. Now he feeds them choice intel, keeping the playing board fair."

She nodded, giving him a small wave before Korric let out a loud exhale. "I've been digging through Forgedeep's top-end shipments. They are mass-printing weapon parts as well as whole crates of high-tier explosives."

Lyra nodded grimly. "As soon as the Titan Hero Guard opened applications, Sector 12C and Verge Line 14E were both flooded."

"It's a purge of anyone and anything they deem monsters," the AI's voice was abnormally serious.

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“The more people we get registered with,” Vexal said calmly, “the quicker we can stop this, as well as react legally to any and all disasters in our sectors. But we must increase our training. As it is, only a small percentage of us would pass the Energy Physical.”

“Energy Physical?” Myth asked, incredulous. “I thought the Hero Guard was for anyone and everyone?”

“That’s just what the initial press conference said,” Vexal answered. “They still only let certain energy types do field work. The ones that are allowed are graded and classified. If you don’t make the cut, you can only do, essentially, desk and volunteer work.”

Myth bit her lip as the conversation picked back up around her. She tried to focus as the room drifted into motion. Lyra was giving Vexal an update, Korric coordinating with the AI. Bryn gave her one last look, then with a small wave he disappeared back into the shadows, Myth realising that she should probably go too, if she didn’t want Darius to come back early and notice her gone. If she even wanted to go back...

She felt Vexal’s hand on her shoulder gently. “Come on.”

He led her down a short corridor into what seemed to be his private quarters. The small room was undecorated; a low bed and a wall of screens made up most of the furniture.

She turned around slowly, finally settling her eyes back on him, her thoughts more resolute. “I want to go back.”

His jaw tensed slightly.

“Everyone is risking their lives, trying to do their part. I want to do mine,” she added.

Something flickered across his eyes before he nodded. “Just... be careful,” he said finally.

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She nodded and checked the time on her comtech. Evening was coming fast, and she didn't want to give Darius any time to notice she had left his room.

She looked up to see him watching her intently. She gave him a small smile. "I guess I'd better get going."

He gave her a short nod, his eyes boring through hers. She smiled again awkwardly, warping away in a haze of jumbled thoughts and feelings.

She landed softly in the centre of Darius's quarters, the lights already dimmed for the evening hours. The smell of him washed over her as she moved slowly to the closet, undressing as she walked. She felt exhausted, the energy in her bones faint, and she knew her face looked tired. She showered quickly before curling up in his bed, her knees tight to her chest as she watched the news, her eyes slowly drifting closed.

She woke to the hiss of the door. Darius was already half across the room, his armour torn open at the throat, his hair a matted mess. His energy was faint, and he looked like he was swaying slightly.

"You're back," he said softly.

She blinked, sitting up quickly. "Are you okay?"

He nodded slowly. "Myth... we need to talk. But tomorrow." His shoulders slumped as he stepped past her. "Just get some rest."

He had barely taken a step when the door beeped loudly, announcing official entry before hissing open. Lynx Kairen stalked in, flanked by two black-clad T.E.B. enforcers. His uniform was crisp and clean, his back ramrod-straight. "Operative Nyx," he said flatly. "Commander Voxx requires a recharge."

Her heart slammed to a stop in her throat, and Darius stood frozen in place.

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“Dr. Ekros has flagged your energy readings as unstable. The Commander has graciously offered a stabilising solution. You can maintain your energy the AAN-sanctioned way—” he motioned to the enforcers, who had already produced a set of heavy steel cuffs “—or, you may report to the Commander’s quarters for a direct synergy infusion.”

Her ears rang at his words, her eyes flying to Darius, the helpless look on his face making her pulse scream through her veins. She looked slowly back to Lynx, his face impatient, his foot already tapping. “Decide. Now.”

Chapter 39

Myth's fingers were almost numb from the cold air in Voxx's private quarters. It was sparsely decorated, containing only a low, minimal bed, his ivory desk, and his weapons in their charging ports. The walls were bare and sterile, a sharp contrast to the breathtaking view from the full-wall-sized window. But the view was the last thing on her mind as she stared at the back of Commander Voxx's head.

Her thoughts numbed in and out, partially from energy loss, partially from boredom. Her hands were firmly anchored into his back as he sat at his terminal. He had spent the entire time typing away at reports, his posture immaculate, his lips in a thin line. She felt like a maintenance drone, just hovering until the energy swap was complete, only to be immediately cleared away. As if on cue, he rolled his shoulders once, standing abruptly.

"Stabilisation complete. You are dismissed, Nyx." His voice was emotionless.

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She let her hands fall to her sides, his words like a cold slap. She saluted shakily and walked past him, her shoulders square, past Lynx's stony face and out into the hallway. She let her shoulders drop as she heard the doors hiss shut behind her, her exhaustion seeping in slowly. Her boots echoed through the quiet halls as she walked, tears blurring her vision momentarily. She didn't know what she had expected from him; he was her Commander, after all. But after everything that had happened over the last few days... She shook her head and stood up straighter, Darius's door coming into view. She needed to focus on one problem at a time.

She found him pacing furiously, freshly showered, his hair still damp from the steam. He turned at the sound of the door, tension tight across every line of his body. His shoulders dropped slightly in relief when he saw her, but the fire didn't leave his eyes.

"What did he do?" His words came out in a gush as he strode across the room. "Are you hurt?"

"No, I'm fine," she breathed into his chest as his arms enveloped her. "He just requested my energy, not full synergising. He worked the whole time."

He pulled away and looked her over one more time before finally nodding, his face still tight. "Come lie down. You must be exhausted," he said finally.

She nodded, moving past him into the room. She undressed quickly, her fingers trembling slightly, before she lay down next to Darius in his bed. He pulled her close in the dark, gently kissing her forehead. Her thoughts were tangled from the lack of energy, and she felt her body shake slightly. He responded by wrapping his arms around her tightly, slowly allowing his energy to surge through her. She felt her body react to his, her energy gently surging against his as his hands found her hips. She squeezed her eyes shut, trying to push the image of Voxx out of her mind, the cold feeling of his energy out of her heart. Hot tears gently fell on her neck,

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Darius's shoulders shaking as he cried silently against her, his energy cool and slow, a stark contrast to his normal, fiery Magma. She rolled over, turning into Darius's chest, her tears falling gently down her face. She pulled him in tight as his arms tightened around her, the ache in her heart finally soothing.

The weeks blurred into months, the cycle-year finally bleeding into the cold and colourless winter. Titan had changed rapidly, the days growing ever shorter while the snow and ice tore through the sectors.

She walked with Darius, bundled into her winter gear, her mind hardly focusing on the uneventful patrol. The new wave of propaganda ads tore through the atmospheric dome silently above them, Helion Prime's daily hero ad playing before the morning sun rose. Each plaza they patrolled and every route pulsed with bright banners displaying hero-forward slogans. Her mind drifted back to the frenzy Titan went into once Voxx had announced the Hero Guard. Within weeks, state-sponsored Hero Agencies sprang up around Titan like spores. Their crystal doors were guarded by T.E.B. bots, their recruiters handing out neon pamphlets on every street corner in every sector.

She had spent the last two weeks at the Halflight Hero Agency in the Outer Pulse of Blackroot Verge. She trained wayward Echelons and up-and-coming Dregs, passing on the mandatory energy training lessons that the AAN mandated every hero know. Lyra was installed as the Director, the number of sympathisers quietly legitimising Dreg-led patrols. Her close proximity made it easier for Myth to get messages from Vexal. She hadn't dared go back to see him in person, tracker out and all, she didn't trust Dr. Ekros or Fane to keep their word.

Even with the flood of heroes, the attacks didn't stop, and Dreg spin-outs were on the rise. Thankfully, there were no more of Fane's monsters; the streets were swarmed with smaller ones.

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Seemingly failed experiments left to run wild, tearing through civilian living sectors mindlessly. Criminals wasted no time in capitalising on the chaos, robbing and attacking wilfully while the heroes were left to try to mitigate the damage.

Myth was exhausted mentally and physically. As the monster attacks increased, so did the AAN's might. All official Apex units were outfitted with mutation-supportive gear and tremendous weapons. Darius wielded twin Magma-tantalum carbide hammers, their faces decoratively forged with Darius's own energy; most average monsters didn't even stand a chance against one of his blows.

She had been sanctioned twin sickles made from an amalgam of her own ribs and energy. Their dark, serrated edges moved through the air like liquid, a constant, swirling barrier around her body, constantly regulating her energy, increasing her output use after use. Kill after kill.

Each completed patrol, she felt herself becoming more numb and confused. Fane's words constantly swirled with the memories of Voxx calling her name when he was dying. He never gave her a second glance or word; she had instinctively lain low the first few weeks, thinking that her cover was surely blown. But nothing. It was confusing and, for some reason, painful. The memories or hallucinations she thought she had when she was dying had faded quickly into nothingness, leaving her never-ending questions.

That evening, she sat at Darius's side, another opulent dinner underway. Another night of mandatory team-building disguised as a dinner. Endless platters of priceless food and a sea of drink, it always shocked her after leaving the poorer and middle sectors, where the average civilian barely had enough food for the day. And it wasn't choice food either. Eating anything these days was purely a performative chore to keep the truth of her mutation quiet. Only a handful of people still knew, and she wanted to keep it that way indefinitely.

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As the night wound down, Darius left her to volunteer for the night patrol in Forgedeep. It was an area that had been hit relentlessly by Vexal and the Rebellion in the never-ending struggle for resources and weapons. She found herself retiring to her own quarters night after night, the cold silence somehow comforting, even though her eyes stayed wide open.

“Go to the Helios Vault if you think you are ready to know. See it for yourself.”

Fane’s words echoed in her ears, her mind running through all possibilities and traps he could have set, even if it did seem unlikely. Something about the conversation, or maybe his eyes, told her he wasn’t lying. But why would he tell her the truth?

She had already located the Vault during a standard archival processing sweep for the Helix Spire after all the damage. Nobody wanted to go through the twelve-hour-long process, and she had been alone for a majority of it. The Helios Vault was a highly restricted medical archive hidden deep in the Frostline Divide. Unreachable on foot and riddled with Glacier Maws. *Maybe Fane was sending her there to be killed*, she mused. Between the cold and the lack of oxygen that far out, she had to prepare for her flight. She would have simply warped in, but every high-access vault had energy suppressors and alarm systems if they read too high an energy index, and she certainly didn’t want the entire AAN raining down on her.

She tossed and turned, mulling it over in her mind, *tonight would be the perfect night...* It had been an easy day, and Voxx hadn’t needed her, choosing to synergise with Lynx, to Myth’s relief. She glanced at her comtech; it was still relatively early in the night, so she could make it there and back with hours to spare to search for information. Her cold-cycle gear came with a breathing mask; all she needed was some warm, non-AAN clothing.

She rolled over again. This is crazy, she thought with a frustrated sigh. She had no idea of the layout once inside, and she would be close to powerless if something happened. She didn’t

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even dare bring her comtech, instead having memorised the lowest-pressure route. She decided she would fly in, using her sickles until she was close enough to see the entrance, then continue on foot.

She stood resolutely and walked into her closet. There was no reason she couldn't warp at least to the edge of the Cryothorne district, that would shorten her trek from Helion massively.

Myth suited up carefully in the dark, her fingers shaking slightly as she clipped the pieces of her dark-weather gear into place. She kept her breathing slow, taking full advantage of the clean air while she could. The southeastern glacial stretch of Titan was mostly sub-zero temperatures and rough, inhospitable terrain. She fitted her breathing mask to her face carefully, the humidifier immediately steaming up her face. With one last check-over, she closed her eyes and focused, the cold of the nightmare horizon bursting around her as she landed hard.

Her armour immediately whitened, the tech reacting to the icy wind blowing down from Cryothorne. She took a deep breath, steadying herself before pulling her sickles from their hip harnesses.

She was standing on the Frostline Shelf, a jagged ice wasteland that fractured into canyons and fissures in a constant ocean of glaciers grinding against one another. The sound tore through the air, her bones rattling slightly from the rumbling ground. That was the least of her problems.

Crystal-wolves. Massive beasts with razor-sharp fins and six eyes, they hunted in packs of hundreds and went berserk at the scent of warm blood. Myth felt a shiver of fear as she saw their hides catch in the faint light, and the air thrummed with their mating calls. Further out, Glacier Maws broke through the cascading waterfall of avalanches, creating their own streams in brutal displays of dominance against the wolves. They could reach up to twenty metres long and

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weigh up to sixty tonnes of blind hatred. She gritted her teeth; she couldn't warp farther not knowing where she was going, but she could make small warped jumps. She took a deep breath and started stealthily making her way across the frozen ocean, keeping her energy low and only warping within sight.

She wasn't even a kilometre in before the first wolf stalked her, the light refracting in soft blues and pinks off its crystal hide. She spun hard, her sickles flashing over the ice, slicing brutally through its throat. She just missed its jugular, and it shrieked in pain, the rest of the pack responding in kind, bearing down on her.

She ran for it, warping as fast as she could across the ice, dodging in and out of packs to confuse the beasts, the scent of her sweat causing them to frenzy. She was out of breath by the time she made it to the far ridge, the Maws carving her way up the mountain, the wolves hot on her tail. She pushed harder, trying to put more distance between herself and danger as the ridge steepened.

She almost passed the Vault, its single black door hidden in a fissure of ice. She skidded to a stop and frantically started clearing the ice and snow with the hilt of her sickle, the howls of the wolves bearing down on her. She felt sweat prick her neck as she slammed her gloved fingers into the panel, trying to punch in the archive code, but the old screen flickered slowly, the ice and age finally catching up with it.

ACCESSING: PLEASE WAIT

She wanted to scream as the howling got closer, the ground shaking violently from their approach. She turned and looked to see they were less than a kilometre away and closing fast, the

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chaos of two Glacier Maws closing in behind them, no doubt ready to take advantage of the bloodshed.

She bit her lip hard and turned, her breath coming fast and hard, the screen still blinking like a beacon in the dark at her.

ACCESS GRANTED

The Vault groaned open slowly, the internal gears sounding like a scream, spurring the wolves on. Her heart was slamming in her chest as she pushed her body through the slowly opening door, immediately slamming her palm on the close-control button as she slid inside.

The door slowly began to close again, a wolf's face shoving through the narrow gap, its jaws snapping just inches from her. Not daring to draw her energy weapons, she watched as the door slowly crushed its head, the beast howling in pain as the door sealed with a seismic boom, a shower of ice and blood raining down.

She sat there for a moment, her chest heaving as the air mask tried to keep up, the howls outside turning into chaos as the wolves feasted on the other end of the dead wolf. She stood up, the light from the Vault flickering as the generators booted up slowly.

Chapter 40

Her boots crunched loudly against the frosted tiles, the temperature inside the Vault much cooler than outside. The Helios Vault was even more vast than she'd imagined, its three spires displayed brilliantly in the entrance, outlining her current location. Shaped like a crown from above, its three spires branched out through Titan's crust. One to Aetherion, one into Nocturne, and one to her, Cryothorne. A faint light fogged on instantly, illuminating steel signage above her, directing her to the elevators. Her gaze swept the lower floor, catching faint, scattered feathers and massive boot prints. Voxx had been here recently. The thought sent another shiver down her spine as she followed his steps to the elevator, hesitating for a moment before selecting

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Floor One: Extraction Archives. There was no way to know what Voxx had been doing here or why, and she didn't have time to investigate.

The elevator was swift, opening silently into a massive floor of darkened terminals. Row upon row, hundreds if not thousands of terminals gridded across the entire area. Only the one at the front was lit, dimly pulsing from the geothermal converters keeping the electricity on. She moved carefully, mindful of the frost underfoot, and as she got closer, the terminal beeped alive, greeting her with a loud ping.

She breathed a sigh of relief, a search terminal, the search query blank and blinking blue. She typed quickly, "Myth," and hit search. The screen blinked off, leaving her in the dark, before she heard a shuddering in the back. A terminal blinked on brightly, steam rolling off it quietly as it warmed up. Myth almost ran to the back, her heart beating in her throat as her eyes immediately started scanning the screen. The file slowly loaded, a picture populating as the information filled in. Her stomach churned violently. It was a picture of her, her eyes closed and hair tucked back, lying flat out on a surgical table, wires protruding from every available patch of skin. She tore her eyes away from the picture and quickly read through the information. It directed to her origin assignment in another vault: Vault 07, in the Obsidian Annex in Nocturne. She frowned. Another dangerous trek? Was this just a wild chase? Her eyes scanned through the rest, but it was sparse. Each entry linked to additional files, all stored in separate sections. Her eyes roamed over the array of dark terminals around her; she couldn't help but wonder if every terminal held a life. She backed away from the terminal and it went dim, leaving her to rush in the dark back to the elevator. She selected the next closest location on the directory, Floor 2B: Genetic Archives.

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The Genetic Archives were colder; deep in the icy rock, the room smelled faintly of burnt plastic and formaldehyde. The same mass of terminals filled the front of the floor, but the back was a huge, ruptured bio-tank. Spiderwebbed cracks encasing the wall behind it, frozen liquid covering the base and parts of the floor. Her stomach churned as she approached the welcome kiosk, typing in her name again. This time the terminal groaned with effort, sifting through the room in a bright array of light before settling on a middle terminal, a video already playing loudly on it.

She rushed over, seeing that the video it displayed was ancient; the shimmering footage showed a group of scientists, all in outdated lab coats, celebrating. A short, round man with a bright red name tag that displayed **DR. VYRE** was recording the video, his teal gloves waving excitedly through the air.

“Project Myth has produced its first viable offspring!!! It's year nine, and we have the first emergence of a child exposed to raw Catalyst radiation, the human embryo mutated and then stabilised! We did it!”

Her throat constricted, the lack of oxygen making it doubly hard to breathe. The next video auto-played, a large heading moving across the top. It showed hundreds of rows upon rows of embryo vials, some completely blackened.

**1ST GENERATION APEX MUTATION // ALIEN CATALYST ENERGIES
IMPRINTED ONTO MODIFIED DNA RESULTING IN MATTER-YIELDING
TRANSMUTATION HYBRIDISATION (“MYTH”)**

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The video continued as time lapsed, showing the eggs developing into full embryos, then fetuses. Some were normal; others were grotesquely mutilated. The terminal displayed scientific information she didn't understand, ending with the experiment having a mixed outcome. Some subjects lived; the rest were non-viable.

She watched as Dr. Vyre extracted a fetus, the procedure brutal and invasive, and inserted it into a nutrient-rich synthetic uterus. The fetus developed, the time-lapse showing constant, heavy monitoring.

She felt a wave of nausea crash over her as she backed away from the terminal. This was her origin. A product of horrific experiments and a test subject in a never-ending quest for power and control? *What happened after? Where did Voxx come in?* She bit back a scream of frustration, her body shaking violently from the cold. She couldn't go to the Obsidian Annex. She needed to find out where Voxx had gone while she was here. She turned on her heel and stalked back to the elevator. Her oxygen was getting low, and she still needed enough to make it back to Helion, but she wasn't leaving without answers. Her fingers hesitated over the floor controls; she didn't have time to go to every single floor. She looked at the directory again and selected the last one, *Floor B9: Cryo-Stasis & Disposal*.

The floor dropped, her heart rushing as they descended into the Vault, the air becoming noticeably thinner. She stopped abruptly, the elevator doors opening with a heavy groan. The temperature plummeted the moment she stepped out, the frostbitten silence broken only by the soft hum of the failing lights. Frost crawled the walls like ivy, and the air smelled heavily of ancient antiseptic. She stepped carefully across the frozen floor, her boots crunching on shattered test tubes and miscellaneous scientific paraphernalia, until she could see the bulk of the room.

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The walls were lined with blackened, cloudy chambers, lined like rows of tombstones, some still sealed with long-dead figures floating inside. At the centre of the chamber sat a large, desk-style terminal that had already flickered to life, a sputtering voice whispering, “Wel-l-l-l-com-m-me, Doc-oc R.....”

Her heart was pounding as she approached it slowly, the index already populating with files as her eyes scanned the cracked screen.

Names. Thousands of names. Some she even recognised: Voxx, T., Ekros, V., and Dryst, F. And then her name, thousands of times. Reiterations of her name, variants of her name, her name enumerated: Mythica, Myth-004, M-133D. It seemed like it went on forever. She clicked on Myth-300; her own face, mutilated and starved, appeared on the screen, clearly dead. Glaring red words flashed underneath: **STATUS: TERMINATED**. A litany of gruesome details followed, and she quickly backed out, her hand shaking violently. She clicked another, and another. Each one, **TERMINATED**. Different faces, different stages of living to be mutilated. Some missing eyes, arms, the whole bottom halves of their bodies, only their heads remaining. All different ages, from embryo to infant, adolescent, to adult.

Her pulse was screaming in her ears, her chest heaving as she fought the urge to faint. If she passed out here, she would freeze to death down here. Her fingers were already completely numb, her arms heavy from the lack of oxygen in her blood. Frozen tears pricked her eyes as she typed her name into the search: simply Myth. One file populated: **M-001X**. The terminal rattled and clicked loudly, the screen retracting to display a documentation hologram. A hunched old man sat with a datapad, his shrivelled face comically framed by large, red-rimmed glasses and his hands covered in gaudy teal gloves. He was wearing a bloody lab coat and he looked exhausted. The title at the bottom of the screen read:

**PROJECT MYTH: DR. VYRE DISCOVERY LOG AAN COURT MANDATE:
PRIMARY APEX DEVELOPMENT NOTES FOR CYCLE 9 TO 47**

The terminal buzzed and hissed in the cold as the playback began in a flicker of static and distortion. The first scene was a young Dr. Vyre, his face eager and eyes bright, speaking rapidly:

“My name is Dr. Aerin Eos Vyre. Subject M-001X’s initial designation was singular: an Apex-class stasis embryo directly exposed to the Catalyst Engine brought aboard the E.S. Daedalus Prime. The only Earth-launched ark that reached Titan thanks to, as we know, the Catalyst Engine.”

The footage cut to a sharp, metallic birthing pod on display in a white, sterile room; inside, a tiny infant with black iridescent skin floated in a thick fluid. Electrodes were wrapped around its arms and torso like vines, and a faint heartbeat echoed through the chamber.

“Early attempts to create safe mutation classes via natural gestation were largely... unsuccessful. The original embryo batch suffered a loss of eighty-seven percent. Out of those, only one survived full gestation: Subject M-001X.”

The screen cut to a different room, and she watched herself as a toddler, skin faded and dull, still wrapped in wires. She was watching something out of frame, silent, her eyes dead.

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“Unfortunately, the fusion of human and alien DNA created a metabolic hunger similar to the Catalyst Well. No synthetic nutrients can satisfy the energy deficit. Solution: to feed the anomaly energy directly. Subject put in stasis for continued genetic cloning. Clone variants unstable, original Myth Project DNA non-replicable.”

The room shown was full of living versions, all variations of her, starving and huddled at the far end of the room. At the front, she was being held in a heavy metal muzzle, her hands tugging at dampener restraints so hard her wrists bled. A teal hand held her by her hair, typing in an unlock sequence before leaving the room. The muzzle dropped, and screams erupted as she tore through the room, blood and energy clouding the screen viscerally.

“Trial 2: The bottom twenty-three percent of variations starved to see energy consumption rate. Subject Myth encouraged to consume the offered genetic material. Responses observed in mutation: increased thirty-two percent energy stress output. Recovered for reconditioning.”

It went on to show more experiments, Dr. Vyre’s voice aging with her as he experimented on everything she ever was.

“Trial 14: Left arm removed from Subject Myth-116. Rejection noted, but pain threshold increased twelve percent. Recovered for reconditioning..... Trial 31: Isolation protocol enforced for all subjects. Time duration: one hundred and twenty consecutive full cycle-years. No stimuli of any sort. Result of experiment: unfavourable.....”

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He droned on through hundreds of trials as their numbers dwindled, all signed off by Dr. Vyre, his name slowly changing to just Dr. E. Her hands trembled violently, her body screaming in pain from the cold, the weight of the doctor's words pressing down on her.

“Subjects reawakened under AAN directive. The Red Meridian Project, Cycle Year 208. Subject Voxx, T. T. is experiencing acute bio-system failure due to catastrophic somatic overclock. Initiating immediate re-sequencing of Project M. Medical Asset M-001X has been deployed from preservation matrix to commence in-situ biological stabilisation.”

A young Voxx flashed briefly before her eyes, a pulse deep in her skull pulsing frantically against her spine as she watched, unable to tear her eyes away from the brutal scene in front of her.

“Project Voxx, T. T. exhibits consistent mutation degradation. Subject M-001X physical repair rate: twenty-nine percent. Synergised repair rate: ninety-two percent. Flags: their neural harmonisation is unpredictable at best, with severe emotional deviation.”

The video was flickering wildly now; the facility was in burning chaos and partially destroyed. Confused variants were wandering around in the rubble. She didn't see herself in the footage, and the doctor's voice crackled on.

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“Cycle Year 212.6: Subject M-001X attempted containment breach, succeeding in her effort of releasing all clone variants and Subject Voxx. Riot conditions resulted, and Project Voxx escaped containment with seven viable clones. Subject M-001X recovered for extreme reconditioning. Remaining subjects terminated.”

The voice was clearly Dr. Ekros’s now, showing an animalistic and abused subject, his voice carrying a cheery lilt to it:

“Cycle Year 214: Project M reinstated due to the return of Subject Voxx. Subject cited extreme physical and mutative degradation, was near cessation. Attempted forcible reintegration of Subject M-001X. Due to complete memory loss, reintegration unsuccessful with catastrophic results. Project Myth and Subject M-001X permanently decommissioned. Escaped variants never recovered, presumed dead.”

The screen finally died, the light above flickering wildly before shutting off, throwing the entire chamber into darkness.

She couldn’t see; she couldn’t think. The cold had finally eaten through her gear, and her bones felt like weighted lead. Panic clawed up her throat as her breaths became shorter and faster, and she felt her legs give out from under her as her vision blurred.

A bright, searing orange cut through the dark, and she heard heavy boots on metal.

“Myth!”

She blinked hard, her vision sharpening just enough to make out Darius, his hair frosted from the cold as his body steamed in the dim light. He picked her up off the frozen floor, his heat

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pouring into her body. He quickly replaced her breathing mask with his own, a rush of fresh air reviving her senses. Relief and guilt flooded through her, and she tried to speak, her words slightly stuttered still. “I— I’m sorry—”

“Not now.” His voice was short as he pulled her quickly to the elevator. “The Crystal-wolves are frenzied at the door from smelling warm blood and energy. Twice over. We need to leave.”

She didn’t say anything as Darius moved through the Vault to the front door, the carnage of the dead wolf charred away from the threshold. He slammed his fingers into the control panel, his agitation rolling off him in waves. The seal broke with a hiss, and the arctic wind blasted at them like a physical wall. He unleashed a blast of pure energy into the waiting flood of wolves, shrieks echoing out into the storm as they fled from the heat and light.

Red lights strobed through the Vault, a loud alarm voicing out coldly:

HIGH ENERGY SECURITY ALERT. LOCKDOWN IN PROGRESS.

“Move!” Darius barked before hauling her out into the bleak night. The crashing avalanches roared as the shelf moved in the wind, and she could barely make out Darius’s transport hovering just above the ice. The engine light was flickering wildly, and Darius didn’t hesitate. He picked her up, heat pouring from his body as he launched forward, the rush of air and ice so cold her face stiffened. Wolves leapt behind him in the shadows, and she swung one arm free, slashing through their crystalline skulls with a blade of raw energy. The ice cracked beneath Darius’s feet as he tumbled into the transport, the doors sealing behind them immediately. The transport walls flashed red as they slid sideways, the wolves howling and

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scratching at the hull. Darius immediately engaged the autopilot, and they leapt above the icy frenzy, soaring towards Helion Prime.

Myth sat curled in her seat, the seat warmer on the highest setting, her body finally starting to register the pain again. Her muscles ached and her lungs spasmed from the oxygen crash. Her hands shook, her fingers screaming in pain from the frostbite. The breathing mask Darius had given her sat loosely in her lap next to her depleted one, another painful reminder of how close she'd come to dying, again.

She didn't dare look at Darius, who remained standing by the control panel, his back turned to her, arms crossed tightly with his armour hissing at the vents.

The longer he stood there, the heavier the silence grew, and she shifted in her seat finally. "Darius. I'm sorry," she started tentatively.

He sighed heavily, not turning to her. "You went to the Helios Vault in the height of not only the winter cycle, but Crystal-wolf mating season."

She flinched at his words, trying to explain herself, but he continued on.

"You triggered one of the entry failsafes. I had to leave people in freezing weather, leaving helping families to rush back here early. Because you wouldn't answer a comtech beacon." He turned finally, uncrossing his arms. "It seems like I am always one step behind your lies."

"That's rich," she shot back, her ire finally rising. "You say that like you didn't let Ekros put a collar in me!"

Darius blinked. "What?"

"You really didn't know that they put a tracker in my spine where I couldn't even use my powers without being electrocuted?!"

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He shook his head slowly. “No. I didn’t. Ekros said it was an energy stabiliser and only temporary. I would have never agreed to something like an energy collar.”

“I just thought because...” she started, her voice faltering. “I thought you didn’t trust me.”

“Thought what? No. **You** don’t get to do this. You have lied to me time and time and time again. You have been sneaking around for months, and honestly, I’m insulted you think I wouldn’t notice. I have lied for you, covered for you, I have rescued you from the brink of death over and over.” His voice cracked. “Every time I save you, Myth, it costs me. And for what? Another lie? Because you think I don’t trust you? What is there to trust? Where are you going? Who are you seeing? Whatever convinced you to go into one of the most dangerous regions to enter a dead Vault? **Why**, Myth?”

She wanted to tell him; she felt tears spill down her cheeks as she felt the transport walls close in on her. “I... I can’t tell you.”

She felt the fire flare off him, his anger rising.

“You can’t tell me? I have never asked you for anything! We are supposed to trust each other with our lives, but it seems like I’ve been the only one trusting.”

She blinked hard, batting away her tears, finally looking at him. His eyes were dark, the flames in them replaced by a cool black. His face was tight and drawn, a frozen gash near his eye from a Crystal-wolf.

“What are you not telling me, Myth? Please. Is it someone else? Family? Just tell me what is going on.” His words were ragged with pain, and she felt a sob escape her throat.

“I’m so sorry, Darius. I don’t want to lie to you, I just... I just can’t tell you yet. I want to, but I can’t.”

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His face twisted, his jaw set into a hard line. He nodded curtly, taking a slow, measured breath before turning back to the control panel, immediately pulling up the terminal and filling out reports.

She wanted to go to him, but she stayed where she was, her body trembling slightly, her tears spilling down her cheeks. She tried to think of something, anything she could tell him. She felt the death knell over what little relationship they had left, and her heart screamed at her, begging her to just tell him. Instead, she tucked her head down, feeling the wall go up between them, what she had learned in the Vault raging in her mind.

Chapter 41

Vexal quietly closed the back door of the Halflight Hero Agency, the smell of recycled air and antiseptic making his nose sting slightly. Slipping in and out of the city was a big risk these days; the AAN had eyes on every corner now, and his face lined wanted boards in every major sector.

He hadn't seen Myth since the night the Hero Act had been announced, trusting Alaric and Lyra to keep in touch with her. But Lyra's last message had been terse: "*She seems very off. Admin.*"

They couldn't dare elaborate over a line now, so he had come himself. He made his way quietly through an empty training room, the strong smell of the jungle and steel wafting through the open ceiling. The administration office was a bleak, cramped cube, lit by a single yellowed window. Originally retrofitted to be a power-stabilisation chamber for mutation overflow cases, it was now used for overflow paperwork and a litany of administrative duties. He quietly shut the

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door behind him without making a sound on the copper dampening composites, their burnished hue laced with errant vines.

Myth sat facing the window on a makeshift bench, hunched over a low desk cluttered with datapads and scattered mission logs. Her hair was in a frazzled bun on top of her head and her uniform was dishevelled. He paused, not sure how to get her attention without startling her, when she looked up abruptly, her body jolting slightly with shock.

He took a step forward into the room, the green-tinged fluorescent buzz mixing with the golden glow of the sun filtering through the window. Her silver eyes were red-rimmed and dull, and her nose and hands were unusually red and chapped. Her face and knuckles showed clear signs of the earliest stages of frostbite. He sighed deeply, dread washing over him. “You went to the Vault.”

She nodded, her tears spilling out in twinkling rivulets. He looked away, his jaw locked tight. He had already been to the Vault, seen the experiments, learned about Vyre, Fane, Ekros... everything. When Myth had first shown up on his doorstep, he had started digging, and after Fane and Ekros became so obsessed with owning her, he had made it his mission to find out anything he could about her origin. And all he found was carnage. So he had stopped. Dropped it completely and hoped that she would focus on killing King.

“I think we need to talk about it,” he said finally, sitting down beside her gently. She didn’t answer; instead, she folded her arms tightly around herself, shaking her head slightly.

“Myth. I—”

“Please. Don’t,” she whispered, her tears coming heavier now.

He slid closer, her shoulder touching his chest.

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“I’m so tired, Vexal. I just want to stop feeling—” Her breath hitched as she whirled on him, her hands clawing at his clothes.

“No, stop! Listen to me, Myth!” His resolve wavered as her desperate, painful kiss met his lips. Her energy was rampaging through her body, her anguish and despair flooding into him. Jagged pulses cracked from her body, rippling the air around them. His hand came up to stop her; he was exhausted. Carrying the rebellion, his own pain, and now she was just using him. But something stirred deep inside him, fueling his own desire, ignited in response to her fervent need. His body shuddered, her energy forcing its way into his body, flooding him with pain and tearing through him.

He felt her hands on his trousers and he shook his head, but she wasn’t listening. He snarled under his breath, his resolve finally crumbling as he forced his energy over hers as she sank onto him. His Rot flooded through her, and instead of her energy roaring to meet his, he felt her slowly unravelling in his hands. Her body started going slack against him as his Rot climbed her skin like ivy, a tidal wave of splintered memories and feelings streaming through him.

He felt his mutation wrap around her core like a tightening fist, threatening to give in to her cold, desperate resignation curling at the edge of her energy. His spine went rigid with realisation, his hands gripping her hips tight enough to bruise, his vision going white around the edges. “Myth. **Stop.**” His voice was raw.

Her arms tightened around his neck like a brace, her forehead hot against his jaw. She wasn’t hearing him, or she didn’t care. Her energy flickered wildly, spewing cold and fiery foreign energies into his body. Residuals of other people, other energy, other thoughts splintered through his body alongside her thoughts and pain. His bloodstream screamed through his body, his heart threatening to burst as the violent energy detonated under his skin.

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She was trying to kill herself through his mutation. The thought screamed through him like a jagged knife. He tore his energy back, his nerves screaming in pain. “**No!**” he rasped, pulling her up by her chin and looking into her broken eyes. “You don’t get to use me to kill yourself.”

Her breathing stuttered, her lips parted like she wanted to deny it, her face streaked with tears. Anger and grief hit him as she leaned forward, her body trembling against his, finally letting her mutation rush in, mending and healing her.

She was crying harder now, her energy rampaging out of control, flooding into him. He felt his body lock up, fighting to keep from being consumed by her. A violent surge of black and gold tore through him, his ribs cracking under the pressure. Fear trickled down his spine as he heard the energy suppressors kick on, remembering the last time her energy ran rampant. He pulled her unbridled energy into his body, fire searing through his veins, making his vision flash black.

He fought to contain the unbridled energies surging through his core, his heart stuttering painfully as her mutation crawled along his skin like jagged gold threads. His skin sizzled as the emergency energy suppressants flashed on, quickly drenching their bodies, the stabilising mist little more than stinging rain against her energy.

He wanted her to stop, but his body was paralysed by the avalanche of repressed emotions finally breaking free. She cried out against him, her body burning against his. His ears felt like they were underwater as he felt his mutation overload his senses, a cold numbness creeping up his fingertips. His arms slowly went numb as she stilled in his lap, her energy finally subsiding.

“Vexal...” she choked between sobs. “I’m sorry... I shouldn’t have...”

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He forced his head to look down, his vision blurring slightly before focusing sharply on the Rot crawling over his skin in thick black swirls, settling into his forearms anchored by scorches of gold. He blinked hard, the storm of energy in him burning every nerve, every feeling, every painful thought. Numbing him. The grief, the panic, the begging, the pain, all burning away in an inferno of mutative energy.

He exhaled shakily, looking at Myth again. She was looking at him with a concerned expression, and he brushed his fingers along her temple, gently tucking her hair behind her ear. He kissed her forehead gently, moving her carefully, easing her back onto the bench.

He stood up slowly, fixing his trousers and walking to the door. He turned to look at her, a guilty look across her features as she clearly tried to find her words.

“Vexal... I—” she started.

“Goodbye, Myth.” The door closed behind him silently, and he swiftly made his way back out into the streets. He pulled his hood up, waiting for something to hit him. Guilt, rage, regret?

Instead, he felt nothing, the cold numbness creeping through his mind like a soothing hand. The bitter air visibly pulsed off the Outer Pulse down into the Verge, breathing around him as he walked along the root-twisted walkways with his eyes unfocused.

As he stepped back into the shadows of his transport, he immediately tapped his comtech. “Lyra,” he said, sitting down stiffly.

The line immediately crackled alive. “I’m in the west bay. Is Myth—”

“I am going to Forgedeep,” he said as he took off. “Ember Crown, the Dustmarkets.”

The line was quiet for a long breath. “What’s there?”

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“One of Fane’s main augmentation sites. He has had a location there for cycle-years, but it has picked up production. Dregs being turned into walking flashcracks in exchange for complete loyalty.” His eyes narrowed forward, his thoughts finally sharpening.

“Will Fane be there?” Her voice was hesitant, but he felt no need to lie.

“I don’t know. Mobilise everyone. Your agency needs to be on the front lines to pull civilians out.”

Korric’s deep voice crackled through the line. “We have three quake teams, a few anchors, and an Echelon. We can be in and out before the T.E.B. can sufficiently mobilise.”

“Why now, Vexal?” Lyra asked suddenly.

Vexal didn’t answer her question. “I am going to be leading the assault. Give me a wide berth. I will be taking out the heavy hitters, and if Fane is there, I want you all to retreat. Make sure the AI is there to control the narrative. Do you understand?”

“Understood.” Their voices came in sync before the line crackled dead. The cabin was silent again, and the vibration of the transport’s engine pressed against his skull. He leaned back, his head tipped against the seat, his eyes half-closed as he wove carelessly in and out of traffic. His hands moved as if they had a mind of their own, veined in black and gold to his mid-forearm, where he expected to feel pain. But he still felt nothing but numbness. A numbness that seeped through his veins, his body, his mind.

The transport shuddered as it broke into the upper lanes over Forgedeeep, heat rolling along the hull as the industrial vents spouted jagged streaks of red magma across the sky. The Ember Crown sat nestled on the volcanic range, a blistering ring of metal and stone high above the civilian and Null sectors that resided in the deep canyons below. Canopy nets stretched across the canyon gaps, separating and protecting the various sectors from the brutal atmosphere.

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The Dustmarkets were so far down they glowed faintly like a crack in the planet's surface, and the closer Vexal cut his transport, the thinner the traffic became. He felt adrenaline steadily flood his veins as he kicked the descent thrusters on, standing as he dropped through the canopy gaps slowly. His eyes scanned the dormant lava tubes as the sky darkened far above him, the canopies effectively blocking out the light. His world became bathed in an orange glow as he passed housing units and stray Ashdogs; a few curious eyes turned in his direction, but most took no notice. He finally found an empty tube and docked his transport into the dark, the Dustmarket only a short drop below him.

He exited slowly, the heat slamming into him like a wall as he used his Rot to cushion his landing. The smell of sharp metal followed, then sweat, food, overheated plastic, and the constant undertones of something burning. The sounds rose up around him in a symphony of market noise and violence.

The heat-dispersing canopy nets criss-crossed overhead, their black carbon fibres glowing along the edges slightly from absorbing an astronomical amount of UV rays. Under them, rows of stalls fought for space, welded and patched onto whatever surface would hold. The inhabitants here had carved massive homes, stores, roads, and monuments into the sides of the obsidian-rich canyons. As he moved through the people, not focusing on anyone in particular, his eyes scanned the colossal tubes, looking for the familiar crest of red, black, and white.

He made his way to the centre of the market and opened his comtech, heading towards Lyra's ping. He felt a shoulder brush against him and flinched away, noticing that a few eyes had begun to look his way, words failing mid-haggle as they recognised him.

He spotted the Halflight transports cutting through the nets from above, his eyes turning upwards to the big, blocky rebellion stripes, the heat from their engines rushing through the

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canyon. Six military-grade transports adjusted to docking ledges, the doors punching open as ramps slammed down. Heavily geared Dregs poured out, the bright red, white, and black insignia of the rebellion visible on their shoulders and chestplates.

Lyra led the stream, her face pinched, her lips in a tight line. Hundreds of operatives spilled down from the ledges in organised streams, some dropping lines into the lowest tiers while others took the stairways.

He didn't greet their salute and started issuing orders. "Evacuate all civilians. Ensure transport passage to any place in Miridan Hollow. Broadcast everything."

A fleet of transports grounded along the further wall behind them, dust and ash flying wild. Korric leapt from the lead transport, his heavy gauntlets thrumming with energy.

"I want you," Vexal didn't skip a beat, "to clean out the upper levels. Anyone that swears allegiance to Fane. We take no prisoners."

Korric nodded with a grunt, the platoon of thick, armoured Dregs following him, their weapons glowing with heavy energy as they charged up for their first assault.

His comtech flickered to life, the Ash King's face coming into view. "Do you wish to broadcast to all of Titan?" came his oily voice.

Vexal nodded, his face impassive.

"Understood." The feed blinked off. Vexal took off his comtech, looking at it for a moment in his hand, before tossing it aside.

He felt his mutation roar to life as he walked to the obsidian edge, closing his eyes before dropping deep into the black market. The canopy nets hissed softly as they bled away underneath him, light filtering down on the hiding, augmented Dregs scrambling for cover.

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He let his field expand, brushing against the ancient stone walls of the planet, a slow expansion that turned everything around them to ash. Dregs attempted to square off with him, charging him with their Fane-given gifts. He wanted to hate them, loathe them, pity them.

But he felt nothing as the corrosion climbed his boots and pulsed out in large arcs, ripping the screams and flesh from everything it touched. He felt blood splash across his face as the sky peeked through overhead, the brilliant red mixing with the ashy blood. He started running, feeling everything and nothing as his energy rampaged against the tide of attacking Dregs.

Overhead, he heard Lyra's teams moving quickly, the tri-colour uniforms moving in and out of the shadows quickly and efficiently, a flood of transports racing away in the sky. As the stream of white slowed, he moved faster, his eyes barely registering the Dregs turning into ash under his fingertips. Their mutations didn't stand a chance; even with Fane's augmentations, they blurred together in waves of ash, voiceless whispers in the wind.

Soon the Dregs were screaming in terror, no longer trying to attack, but fleeing deeper and deeper into the tunnels. He stopped at the end of the canyon, faced with an imposing wall of obsidian, peppered with hundreds of hollowed-out tubes and cave systems. The wall reached up to the surface of Titan, the red sky screaming with magma above him. He had found it.

He heard screaming and scrambling echoing from deep inside. Hundreds of Dregs had escaped inside, but the only way out of these tunnels was in, or through a volcanic vent. Overwhelming power vibrated through his bones, exploding out of his body in a massive, arcing vortex.

It ripped up the wall in a terrible storm of black and pain. He heard a broadcast going loudly above him, a few news drones fighting to stay aloft in the heavy tide of ash. His mutation

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sliced through the tunnels, the entire structure collapsing into feathery light ash in a slow avalanche of black. Screams radiated through the air before cutting short, the last of the Dregs consumed by his mutation. The storm around him increased, finally reaching bedrock, leaving nothing but a spacious field of ash.

As the dust and ash settled around him, he turned to see all of the Rebellion's responders standing in formation, watching in awe. Fane had clearly not been inside, but Vexal knew it was only a matter of time before they faced retaliation, so they would take out as many of Fane's footholds as they could, as fast as they could. They would leave nothing for him to fall back on, and force Fane Dryst to fight his own battles.

Chapter 42

Helios Caen King sat very still as the world spun around him in a whirlwind of gold and crystal. The imposing atrium of the House of King glowed in layered shades of gold and winter-white as inlaid veins of sunstone ran through the vaulted ceiling, bending into a polished halo.

Snow drifted lazily beyond the wall of windows, but inside, hundreds of candles burned in tiered crystal cages, their flames flickering gently in the waning light. A string quartet of Luminal musicians played from an elevated platform behind him, their instruments wired with light-threads that hummed softly through the air.

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His uniform was traded for a white-and-gold formal resonance suit, fitted regally, with golden tassels glinting along his back in the ambient light. His cape was stark white, the House of King emblem stamped into the silken resonance cloth. He wore his family rings like his father, and large gold cuffs sat heavy on his arms.

The conversations around him drifted across his skin; a familiar repetition of arguments echoed through the hall. The House of Solaris was there, visiting before the Cryothorne Winter Solstice began, enjoying a private festival for themselves before the sectors were allowed to celebrate.

“Cryothorne will make a spectacle as always,” his father, Lord Cassien King, snorted loudly, his heavy hand, encased in massive golden rings, hitting the marble table, his eyes flashing brightly. “A week of parades and ice sculptures while what? While Fane has his way with the planet?”

“Our people, as well as yours, like their theatrics,” Lady Isalya Solaris replied, her tone cold, but her frosty-blue cheeks tinged pink in the candlelight. “And it keeps morale high. You cannot hold a city in permanent austerity and expect blind loyalty. You have to give the people something.”

Helios resisted flinching at her words; morale would be damaged beyond repair if they lost the whole of Titan while they slept. He took a long drink out of his goblet, the crystal a welcome cool against his lips.

“Well then, Cryothorne will bankrupt itself on pageantry, gaudy displays, and frivolities,” his father stated, swirling his Aurelian nectar in a glass carved from a single sun-diamond. His ceremonial breastplate had been polished to a blinding finish, the filigree and edges scattering light in aggressive shards across the room.

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“It is not the festival itself that is the problem,” Lady Solaris said.

“Honestly,” Eira chimed in, walking over to the table from chatting with one of his other cousins. “It’s a strain on resources. Cryothorne is already stretching its power grid to keep the outer rings moving. If Forgedeep could keep supplies moving...” She left off in a loud, pointed voice, obviously aimed at Darius across the room.

Darius turned from where he was talking to Nyx and Helios’s twin cousins to throw her a double finger.

Soft laughter danced through the room, the comment obviously aimed at Darius’s very noticeably absent grandfather, General Valkyrie.

“Will you not be putting on a show this cycle then, Cassien?” Lady Solaris asked coyly, running a finger across his father's glass, a small streak of frost spidering down the rim and frosting the drink.

“Well of course!” he boomed with a hearty laugh. “As you said, we have to reassure the Null districts!”

Laughter rippled through the room again, cheer and curiosity flitting through the air. A full House of King appearance anywhere was turned into a sanctified spectacle; this surely would be no different.

“And we have a new Apex-class Quasar to thank Sir Providence for as well!” Helix King, Helios’s sandy-haired younger brother, quipped.

“Anomaly-class,” Cassien corrected, his lip curling, his eyes glancing over to where Nyx stood laughing with Darius and one of the cousins of the House of Solaris, blissfully unaware of the turn of topic.

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“Nevertheless,” Isalya interjected coolly. “We are grateful for all the blessings that Titan bestows upon us.”

Murmurs echoed around the atrium, soft and sharp. “Blessings,” they murmured in unison.

“Helios,” Lady Solaris said, turning her attention back to him with a small, flirtatious smile. “I do hope you will be joining us in Cryothorne? Or does Mereen have you somewhere else?”

“As if they don’t have any better use for him,” Cassien snorted, “than parading you around your frozen palace!”

“It would be my pleasure,” Helios answered with a diplomatic smile in her direction, noting how her eyelashes lowered just a fraction.

His father loudly poured another drink, raising the thin flute in a toast. “Well then! My son has decided the House of King and the House of Solaris will both be shining brightly side by side this coming cycle! Sir Providence be blessed!”

Helix rolled his eyes, loudly muttering about how Providence played favourites amidst the cheers. Eira flicked his shoulder gently, frost crackling briefly over his sleeve before she smoothed it away with a coy grin. Helios frowned.

Someone at the far end of the table started a new argument, and Helios let the noise blur away. He felt a faint pressure build at the base of his skull and he looked around, wondering whose energy signature was pulsing on the verge of control.

Helios tried to relax, but the thrum of energy under his skin kept him on edge. Finally he set his goblet down, the decisive note of crystal against marble cutting through the noise. “Excuse me.”

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He offered a small nod to the table, dismissing himself and striding out past the quartet, the music fading behind him abruptly as he absent-mindedly moved through the corridors, his mind distracted.

His study was dimmer than the atrium, the single gold-and-crystal chandelier above tinkling gently in the cool air. The old-world Cappelletti Royal writing desk and furniture were bathed in golden rays from the wall of crystal overlooking the tiered spires of Helion Prime cutting into the waning light.

His eyes flickered over the stack of datapads that sat on his desk, edges still aligned with military precision with the terminal at the centre. He closed his eyes for a moment, savouring the cool, familiar atmosphere as he rolled his shoulders back.

A soft rustle of fabric sounded behind him, and the faint click of his office door being locked brought him back.

He opened his eyes and turned, seeing Isalya had let herself in, crossing the room in a white-and-blue flurry of frost, stretching out on the low couch. He walked over and sat on the low table in front of her, eyeing the frost gently curling through the air. Her bright-blue eyes darkened as she tipped her head back, looking up at him with half-closed eyes.

“You left me alone with your father and I had barely finished one drink,” she smirked in a low voice.

“We call that ‘abandoning ship’ where I’m from,” he lowered his face towards hers with a smirk.

“Do you know how many times he said ‘glass the Verge’ tonight? Mhm?” She flopped back with a dramatic laugh, her blue skin almost iridescent in the light.

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“He’s consistent! What can I say?” Helios laughed, spreading his arms wide and unbuckling his cape in a flourish.

“I think he just likes to hear himself talk,” she countered with a snort. Frost curled lazily up her sapphire ankle, her bare calves stretching over the back of the white sofa. Her dress was a slash of white against her cerulean skin. “If he keeps harping on about Cryothorne’s ‘frivolity,’ I am going to freeze his tongue to his teeth and claim it was an energy flare.”

“You will cause an incident, again,” Helios murmured.

“Less of an incident than you having the newest budding Quasar under your roof,” she quipped back.

His jaw tightened and he leaned back. “Nyx is under control.”

“So I’ve heard,” she replied flippantly. “An anomaly on a barely existent leash sounds much more generous. Do you trust her?”

“She’s not my partner and not mine to trust. Voxx has—”

“Quasars are not notorious for respecting reputation, let alone each other.” She ran a frost-blue nail down his arm, leaving a trail of ice.

“The same thing could be said for your daughter.” His voice was smug as a smile crept across his face.

That earned him a sharp smile. “Yes, which is why she is on a very, very short leash. The AAN needs her as the symbol of Cryothorne, and people need their symbols.”

“The people need heat and food, and structures that don’t collapse,” he said pointedly.

“And grids nationwide that don’t blow every time someone with a powerful mutation sneezes!” Isalya added dryly. “Yes. I am aware.”

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She shifted up, sitting so she could look him squarely in the face, the motion dragging her dress high along one thigh. Frost crystallised at the top of the diamond-encrusted silken slit.

“Helion keeps telling us to hold out for the Foundation Track, hold out for enough Lummies to get it together enough to fix the Catalyst Wells, hold the Null Zone. Meanwhile,” she huffed, his eyes dragging momentarily to the ice curling down her neck, “Fane is crawling around my rings like he owns them!” She caught sight of his wandering eyes and snapped her thin, blue fingers at him.

He sighed and dragged his eyes slowly over her body back to her face. “There is nothing I myself can do for you about any of that at this exact moment. I’m coming to the festival and so is the rest of the Apex Corps. That is the best assurance I can give you that everything will be fine.” He slid to the edge of the table, his knees brushing the couch. Up close, the blue iridescence under her skin was even more eye-catching, a sharp contrast to her silvery-white hair. He held out his hand, and she rested her face against his palm. Her hand came up and he grabbed her wrist, his grip like iron pulling her up just enough to toss her over his lap as he settled into the cushions.

“About time,” she murmured, her lips finding his, an icy storm slamming through him.

His hands found the back clasp of her gown, an intricate frost-threaded fabric, and ripped it away from her body. She retaliated in kind, her sub-zero hands tearing at the front of his formal wear, the expensive golden buttons flying open from her barely-contained power.

He drove into her, her icy body wrapping around him, the temperature dropping so low it made his breath catch. His Solar Resonance flared on reflex, the white-hot heat rising as each thrust sent a shockwave of energy through her body.

Shadows of Titan

Their bodies tangled together in a whirlwind of power, the couch beneath them groaning, the ancient frame creaking in protest as the air crackled with static. As their minds began to parallel, her power unleashed a wave of frozen calm through his body, her mutation a welcome relief.

As the pressure in his body peaked, their comtechs both blared to light and they both jerked apart, his heartbeat pulsing through his ears as the screen blackened and a jagged crown of black flared across a field of red. Underneath, clean white text read:

THE ASH BLIGHT REBELLION'S SUCCESSFUL EFFORT OF PURGING THE FORGEDEEP DUSTMARKETS OF FANE DRYST. THE ONLY EMERGENCY RESPONSE TEAM ON SITE WAS THE HALFLIGHT HERO AGENCY. THANK YOU TO THEM AND VEXAL OPHEDIUS. THE DUSTMARKETS REPORTED ZERO CASUALTIES AND ALL CIVILIANS RETURNED TO DUTY.

He felt Isalya's fingers dig into his skin, ice flooding his veins as she seethed, "Oh, for fuck's sake."

The black dropped, replaced by the Dustmarkets view from a high vantage point, heat and dust causing the frame to flicker. The camera panned, tracking a Halfflight squad as their red, white, and black uniforms cut crisp formations against the ash.

He felt his hands dig into her icy hips as he saw civilians filing out of the canyon, transports leaving in a perfect single-file line while a dark-clad Vexal Ophedius blazed a trail of ash through the mutated Dregs, leaving nothing behind. A clean and perfectly efficient response. One Apex Dreg did in a minute what the Corps had been failing to do for cycles.

Shadows of Titan

“Treason,” Isalya seethed, her voice tight. The feed ended with an Ash King AI broadcast channel. She leapt off his lap in a flurry of ice as he righted himself. His energy, chaotic and wild, roared through him, his thoughts honed and narrow. Finding his cloak, he secured it before triggering the liquid breathing mask. He heard her rushing out of the room behind him as he flung the balcony doors open, the crystal booming against the metal walls. With one step he walked into the night sky, the freezing air rushing past him as his energy rushed around him, light exploding out of his body.

He saw Darius’s white transport jetting to the AAN tower, and he exploded ahead. The wind roared past his ears as his mind whirled, the lingering ice of Isalya’s hands pricking his skin. He cut harder through the air, the face of Ophedius, his half-cyborg face burning a harsh image in his mind, the tendrils of dark Rot and ash curling around everything in his way.

Zero casualties were almost unheard of; even for him that was a rare accomplishment. Even if they had just got lucky, the AAN would want a formal reaction.

He broke the cloud layer as the Ascension Spire speared up to meet him, the polished obsidian glass twinkling in the evening light. He didn’t bother with the transport bay as he noted Darius and Nyx racing along the arced pathway from the bay to the briefing room. Instead, he dropped into a vertical dive, slicing through the open roof and slamming onto the dais in a flash of white and ice. The impact sent a tremor through the deck as the rest of the Apex Corps flooded the room in a clamour of voices.

Mereen rushed forward, her clothes festive, but her expression furious. “General.” Her voice cracked across the room like a whip, dozens of conversations stopping as she strode onto the dais. The last wisps of frost rolled off him as he stepped to the head of the room with Voxx and Mereen.

Shadows of Titan

She stabbed an angry, gloved finger at the central terminal, the air above it igniting into a frozen frame from that ratty AI's broadcast.

The Dustmarkets in all their grimy glory, a clear view of Ophedius's face outlined with the damning white text outlining the indisputable victory.

Zero casualties. For a hero agency that was a celebratory win, but for a Dreg hero agency?

Mereen finally spoke, her voice dangerously quiet. "There is a Winter Solstice victory parade happening in the Dustmarkets right now, in fact."

A wave of muttered curses and disgruntled threats rippled through the group, and he felt Eira's frost sharply as it exploded in a sheet underfoot.

"Treason!" Seren Kaelith practically yelled, his mirrored body causing the light around him to dance wildly as his body blinked in and out of sight.

"Everyone, somehow, was late to the party. While this Dreg hero agency..." Mereen seethed. "While we can scrub the servers, we cannot, in fact, scrub the entire planet's memory."

"So let's be precise!" Voxx cut in, his voice a low thrum of barely-contained fury. "The official record should state that the AAN was on site; we, alongside a local Hero Agency, achieved a perfect civilian extraction in a zone where collateral was unacceptable. It will be a testament to how wise the AAN is for having sanctioned heroes in the first place."

The small silence that followed was thick with energy. Lynx stepped into the light, his finger pointing accusingly at Halflight. "Terminate their hero licences."

Nyx and Rhea both started protesting. "They saved hundreds of families!" Rhea's voice carried over the din.

"You will make them martyrs!" Nyx's voice followed after.

Shadows of Titan

“We don’t negotiate with terrorists who wear hero badges!” Eira screamed, ice lancing through the room towards Nyx.

Darius blocked the blast easily with his gauntlet, his voice enraged. “Terrorists? Are you insane?!”

“Oh, don’t play holier-than-thou with me! You have erased a sector block for significantly less!” she spat back, Mereen holding her back by her shoulders.

Lynx leapt to the centre, his Nullify-field battling with the push of Apex energy. “Why don’t we ask your partner there then, Darius? Hm? Since she is training them. Is one of them!”

“What was their plan, Nyx?” Mereen asked pointedly.

All eyes turned to her, but her dark face was impassive. “If you’re asking if I knew this raid was coming, no, I did not,” she said, her voice flat. “I was at the King estate with Darius when this went down anyway.”

“Oh, how fortuitous,” Eira sneered, the room dropping colder, Lynx’s nullification taxed to the limits, unable to hold back the continuous overflow of mutations in the room. “The rebellion’s best spy is winning and dining, conveniently, hundreds of kilometres away. What? Too big a risk of getting caught on camera?”

Darius rounded on her. “Say that to my face, Ice Princess!” His body flamed violet-orange.

Helios almost stepped forward, but Rhea was quicker. “Accusing each other is not going to solve the problem!”

“What even is the problem?” Dr. Ekros said, his face coming out of the shadows. “This would be a perfect time to work with the responsible agency and gather more intel on Ophedius, not alienate them. Certainly not during the Winter Solstice.”